打虎记
To Slay a Tiger

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白屋
The Cage CH34701-01

Cheng's House, Ancient Zhu County
古祝县·程宅

The cold sky presses down on black tiles. Black tiles press down on white walls.
冷澈的天压着黑色的瓦，黑瓦压着白色的墙。

At the foot of these walls is a courtyard. Though swept clean that morning, a light dusting of snow has already begun to reclaim it.
墙下是清晨新扫过的院子。不过几个时辰，上面便又积了薄薄一层雪。

Chéng Héguāng carries firewood into the house and lights the stove.
程和光抱着木柴进屋，给炉灶生了火。

Cheng Heguang: Copying documents at the Yamen still earns me around 30 wen a day.
程和光：在衙门抄书，折下来一天仍是三十文左右。

He takes the ledger and inkstone down from a nearby shelf, dips his brush in ink, and carefully records the day's income and expenses.
他从架子上取下账本与砚台，取笔蘸墨，细细记录今日的收支。

Cheng Heguang: One bass sold for seven wen.
程和光：售卖鲈鱼一条，赚得七文。

Cheng Heguang: Expenses: leaf celery, four wen. One jin of salt, five wen. Medicinal herbs, ten wen.
程和光：支出：芹菜四文，盐一斤五文，药材十文。

Cheng Heguang: Hm?
程和光：嗯……

Someone steps lightly behind him and drapes a coat over his shoulders.
有人轻步走到程和光身后，给他披上一件衣裳。

Mother: Back already? *cough* My, every winter feels colder than the last.
母亲：回来了？咳……冬天一年比一年冷了。

Cheng Heguang: You should be in bed. I only went to see Doctor Wú for some Baibu; he said you should be resting.
程和光：您不该起来的。我刚去吴郎中那里抓了些百部，他之前也说静养——

Mother: Alright, alright. But why did you go to him again? Don't you usually go to Jishitang?
母亲：好了，你怎么又去他那里？平时不是去济世堂么？

Cheng Heguang: I wanted a new prescription. I heard he'd just made a new batch of Dazao pills.
程和光：我想请他开副新方子——我听说他又新制了些大造丸。

Mother: Did you get some?
母亲：拿到了吗？

Cheng Heguang: ...
程和光：……

Mother: *sigh* I told you not to go there! In fact, I said we should've cut ties with him long ago.
母亲：唉，我早不许你去！早说要断绝来往。

Mother: Started up with his usual nonsense, did he? Refusing to let you inside, using some "illness" as an excuse? *cough, cough*
母亲：他是不是又对你说些浑话，不许你进门，说是因为病气……咳咳。

Chéng pauses for a moment and closes the ledger.
程和光顿了一下，合起账本。

Cheng Heguang: It's no matter. I have the medicine. I'll start brewing it now.
程和光：无妨。药买回来了，我这便熬药。

Mother: What did he say?
母亲：他说了什么？

Cheng Heguang: ...
程和光：……

At the doorway, the branches of a Mei tree shake off a few clumps of snow.
门口的梅枝抖落几抔雪。

Thankfully for him, a sudden knock at the door interrupts the awkward silence.
一阵叩门声适时地打断了尴尬的沉默。

Mother: Expecting someone?
母亲：有客人？

Mother: We haven't had a visitor since your uncle returned to the countryside.
母亲：自你二叔搬回乡下，家里好久没来人了。

Chéng puts the ledger back on the shelf.
程和光将账本放回架上。

Cheng Heguang: I'll take a look.
程和光：我先去看看。

Chéng trudges back through the snow to the courtyard gate and raises the latch.
程和光踏雪走回院门，抬起门闩。

A familiar military officer stands outside.
门外站着一位熟悉的武官。

Cheng Heguang: Commander Lì?
程和光：厉守备？

Li Huifeng: Hmm. Héguāng, I hope I'm not intruding.
厉晦锋：嗯。和光，没打扰到你吧？

Cheng Heguang: Not at all. I just returned from the clinic and was preparing to brew some medicine.
程和光：我刚从医馆回来，正打算熬药。

Li Huifeng: How is your mother these days?
厉晦锋：……令堂的病情如何了？

Cheng Heguang: Consumption is not easy to treat.
程和光：痨病难治。

Cheng Heguang: Are you here on official Yamen business?
程和光：您找我，是衙门有事？

Lì Huìfēng offers a faint, amiable smile.
厉晦锋对他露出了一个可称和蔼的笑容。

Li Huifeng: The Yamen's affairs have nothing to do with me.
厉晦锋：衙门的事不归我管。

Li Huifeng: I'm here to offer you an opportunity.
厉晦锋：我这次来，是为了给你一**个机会**。

Cheng Heguang: ...!
程和光：……！

Chéng returns indoors, clutching a yellowed sheet of paper.
程和光攥着一张泛黄的纸返回屋内。

The lid of the pot on the stove has already been lifted, the cooked rice porridge inside sending steady curls of steam into the air.
炉灶上的锅盖已被掀开，熬好的米粥正冒出腾腾的热气。

Out of habit, he takes the ladle from his mother's hand.
他习惯性地从母亲手里接走了汤勺。

Cheng Heguang: Let me take care of this.
程和光：这些事我来做就好。

Mother: Who was it at the door, then?
母亲：刚刚是谁?

Cheng Heguang: It was Commander Lì.
程和光：是厉守备。

Chéng brings the porridge to the wooden table and casually passes the paper to his mother.
程和光把粥端上木桌，顺手把那张纸递给母亲。

Cheng Heguang: Tomorrow, I'll ask if Auntie can come lend her hand for a while.
程和光：……我明日去找二姨，拜托她来照顾一阵。

Cheng Heguang: It will be a long journey.
程和光：我要出趟远门。

A few sparrows flit past the window, chirping as they flutter out of the courtyard.
几只麻雀掠过窗外，叽叽喳喳飞出了院子。

Street, Riverside Village
水乡·街道

This small village, governed by another county of Huanzhou Prefecture and nestled between mountains and rivers, has simply come to be called the Riverside Village.
程和光：这是涣州府别县治下的一个小村落，依山傍水，故称水乡。

This Riverside Village looks much like Zhu County. At its entrance, Chéng Héguāng sees the familiar rise and fall of black tiles once again.
程和光：水乡的风貌与祝县相似。程和光走到村口，又一次看见了黑瓦所勾勒的起伏轮廓。

Only, today's early afternoon is not quite as peaceful as usual.
程和光：只是今日的晌午不如往日般宁静。

Lead Villager: My brother's been mauled by a tiger! He's damn near on his deathbed! And you dogs have the gall to stand here, pushing us around?!
乡民首领：我兄弟被大虫咬伤，命悬一线！你们这些走狗还在这推三阻四！

Cheng Heguang: ...?
程和光：……?

To the left of the village entrance stands an exceptionally grand courtyard, with a memorial Paifang outside bearing the words "Loyalty, Filial Piety, Integrity, and Righteousness."
村口左侧是一处华贵非常的院落，门外还竖立着“忠孝节义”的牌坊。

A group of villagers have gathered beneath the Paifang, their faces flushed as they shout at the household guards blocking their way.
牌坊下已经聚了些面红耳赤的乡民，正对着拦阻的家丁叫嚷。

Cheng Heguang: Likely the residence of a local gentry.
程和光：……应是本地士绅的房子。

Chéng approaches without a word, slipping in among several bystanders.
程和光沉默靠近，混入周围几个看热闹的闲汉中。

Stern Guard: Doctor Xiù was paid for with the family's hard-earned silver! She's inside treating Master Hú. How dare you try to barge in!
严肃的家丁：秀郎中是我家真金白银请来的！她正在里面给朝奉开方把脉，岂能容得你们乱闯！

Lead Villager: Doctor Xiù is the village physician, not the Hú family's private attendant!
乡民首领：秀郎中是咱们水乡的医生，又不是你胡家自己的！

Lead Villager: What could be more urgent than a life-or-death situation?! What right do you have to stop us? What are you hiding in there?
乡民首领：什么病比人命还紧急！你凭什么拦着我们？你家有什么不能见人的宝贝吗？

Lead Villager: Tell Doctor Xiù there's a patient out here on the verge of death! I know she'll come out to save him!
乡民首领：你进去和秀郎中说，这有个快死了的病人——她一定会先出来救人！

Stern Guard: You'll just have to find another doctor. If you set off now for the county, you can make it there before nightfall.
严肃的家丁：你就非要看这一个大夫不成？不如早早动身去县里，还来得及天黑前进城。

Lead Villager: We already hauled him all the way down the mountain to Doctor Xiù's clinic, only to be told she was here!
乡民首领：我们下山就去了秀郎中的医馆。伙计说她在你们家，我们便一路颠簸走到这——

Lead Villager: Just look at him! Does he look as though he'll survive a trip to the county?!
乡民首领：你看他，还像是能挨到县里的样子吗?!

The injured villager is slumped over his companion's back, his hastily bandaged left arm soaked with blood.
受伤的乡民伏在同伴背上，草草包扎的左臂已是血肉模糊。

Stern Guard: That's none of our concern. We had no hand in his injuries.
严肃的家丁：这些我不管，又不是我们伤了他。

Stern Guard: If you continue causing a scene outside Master Hú's house, we'll call the bailiff over to have you arrested!
严肃的家丁：你们再这样围着胡朝奉的院子生事，我们就要叫保长来抓人了！

The lead villager explodes in fury.
为首的乡民怒喝一声。

Lead Villager: Go on, call him! You're all in cahoots with one another anyway!
乡民首领：叫吧，叫吧！你们原本就是一伙的！

Lead Villager: Hú Hǎiyuè is so afraid of dying. He summons a doctor every time he nicks his skin.
乡民首领：胡海岳怕死，手划破一道口子也要请郎中开药——

Stern Guard: Watch your mouth, you slanderer!
严肃的家丁：你别血口喷人！

Lead Villager: Our man's been mauled half to death, and you won't even let him through the door!
乡民首领：咱们的人被咬成重伤，连门槛都迈不进去！

Calm Villager: They waited until land prices were low and took two acres of my land in exchange for just one tael of silver.
冷静的乡民：他家趁着田价贱，用一两银子就买了我两亩地……

Disheartened Villager: Last year, I had a funeral to arrange and was desperate for money. The Hú family loaned it to me but charged five percent interest.
沮丧的乡民：去年我因为丧事，急需用钱。胡家放债，最后竟然要收我五分的利息……

The lead villager snatches a bow from his companion's hands and aims it at the household guards. A wave of shock ripples through them.
乡民首领夺过同伴手里的弓箭，竟对着家丁拉开了弓。

Lead Villager: The Hú family's out to ruin us all! First they snatch up our fields, then they hound us with debt! They're driving us to death!
乡民首领：胡家就是故意欺负我们！不是买田就是追债，不想让我们活了！

Lead Villager: Fellow villagers, tell me, does this sound fair to you?!
乡民首领：乡亲们，你们说这公平吗！

Villagers: No!
乡民们：不公平！

The rest of the villagers shout, their hoes and clubs raised high.
其余乡民愤怒地应和，举起手中的锄头和棍棒。

Lead Villager: We're done waiting! We're not taking it anymore!
乡民首领：我们等不了！我们不忍了！

Lead Villager: One way or another, I am going through that door!
乡民首领：我今天非要进门不可！

Villagers: We'll not be pushed around! Burn down the gate! We'll force our way in!
乡民们：咱们也不是好欺负的，把他家大门烧了！闯进去！

The household guards draw their swords, raising their shields into a solid wall.
家丁们抽出腰刀，举起盾牌，组成一堵密不透风的人墙。

Stern Guard: Go ahead and try! This is nothing short of rebellion.
严肃的家丁：那你们就试试！简直是要造反——

Before the words even finish leaving the guard's mouth, an arrow flies toward his forehead.
话音刚落，一支羽箭已经向着家丁的眉心飞来。

But before it can strike, it is cleaved in two by a flash of steel.
——只是未及射中，便被刀光劈为两半。

Chéng sheaths his blade, stepping between the guards and the villagers.
程和光：程和光收刀入鞘，挡在家丁与乡民中间。

Cheng Heguang: This man is dying! What harm is there in letting him inside?
程和光：人命关天，放他们进去又有何不可？

Stern Guard: Who are you?!
严肃的家丁：你是谁?!

Calm Villager: He's not one of us.
冷静的乡民：不是我们的人……

The crowd exchanges glances like a theater troupe interrupted mid-performance, unsure of what to do next.
人们面面相觑，像是被打断了演出的戏班，不知如何是好。

Stern Guard: You—
严肃的家丁：你——

The gate is suddenly thrown open.
紧闭的大门被人猛然推开。

???: What is going on out there?!
???: 外面在吵什么！

访虎
The Tiger CH34701-02

Calm, unhurried footsteps emerge from the courtyard.
从院子里踏出来的步伐不慌不忙，平稳轻盈。

Cheng Heguang: Seems they've had martial arts training.
程和光: 应该是习武之人。

The guards hastily make way, their voices softening with deference.
家丁慌忙往旁边避让，语气也恭敬起来。

Stern Guard: D-Doctor Xiù, have you finished examining Master Hú?
严肃的家丁: 秀、秀郎中？您瞧完朝奉的病了？

Doctor Xiu: You mean his night blindness? Exactly how much time do you expect me to waste on that man?
秀郎中: 一点夜里看不清东西的小毛病，还要多久来治?

Doctor Xiu: And you, out here making a racket and swinging your weapons about while I'm trying to write a prescription!
秀郎中: 倒是你们——我正写着方子，却在这吵吵嚷嚷，动刀动枪！

Doctor Xiu: Care to explain yourselves? Hm?
秀郎中: ……嗯?

She takes the steps two at a time, passing Chéng without so much as a glance.
她停住话头，径自走下台阶，从程和光的身旁穿过。

The villagers all lower their weapons, allowing her to approach the gravely injured man. She narrows her eyes as she examines him.
乡民们放下武器，任她走到伤者面前眯眼观察。

Doctor Xiu: How did this happen?
秀郎中: 怎么伤的?

Disheartened Villager: We were hunting in the mountains and ran into a tiger. My brother, he fell behind and—
沮丧的乡民: 我们进山打猎，遇上了老虎。我兄弟落在最后——

Before he can finish, Doctor Xiù turns and strides back toward the gate.
秀郎中不待听完，便疾步走回大门。

Doctor Xiu: Get him in here!
秀郎中: 马上抬进来！

Stern Guard: But Doctor Xiù! He's covered in blood! How could we possibly carry him into Master Hú's courtyard?!
严肃的家丁: 秀郎中！这人浑身是血，怎么能抬进朝奉的院里?！

Doctor Xiu: It's bad luck for someone to die at the gate, is it not? I'll ask Master Hú for a room myself!
秀郎中: 在大门口死了人不是更晦气？我自去让你家朝奉给我分间房！

She pauses, then turns back impatiently.
她顿了口气，不耐烦地转身催促。

Doctor Xiu: Well? Unless you wish for this man to die, I suggest you bring him in!
秀郎中：还不抬进来，等死吗?

Lead Villager: Ah, r-right.
乡民首领：啊，是、是。

Lead Villager: Quickly, let's get him inside!
乡民首领：快把他背进去!

Two villagers rush the wounded man inside, streaking the entrance steps with blood as they ascend.
两个乡民匆忙把伤者背入院内，在门口的台阶上留下一路血痕。

Cowardly Guard: Should we wipe it up? If it dries, it'll be harder to clean.
怯懦的家丁：要擦吗？等下干了就不好擦了……

Stern Guard: Of course, you dolt! Unless you're looking for a scolding, you'll wipe it this instant!
严肃的家丁：擦啊！擦啊！不擦等着挨骂吗?

The guards fetch water from the courtyard and begin hurriedly scrubbing Master Hú's steps.
飞扬跋扈的家丁们从院内打了水，忙着擦拭胡朝奉的台阶。

Lead Villager: Hmph. Despicable!
乡民首领：哼……小人。

Cheng Heguang: All's well that ends well, it seems.
程和光：应该无事了。

Chéng is just about to leave when the lead villager steps in to block his path.
城中居民 III：程和光正待离开，却被乡民首领拦住了去路。

Lead Villager: Wait.
乡民首领：等等。

Lead Villager: Who are you? Why did you cut down my arrow?
乡民首领：你是谁？为何要拦下我的箭?

Cheng Heguang: Only a passing traveler. Your arrow would never have pierced that guard's rattan shield, but it would have given them a reason to retaliate.
程和光：我只是个路过此地的旅人。你的弓箭劣质，无法射穿藤牌，反而给了对方回击的理由。

Cheng Heguang: Your recklessness will cause nothing but trouble.
程和光：激动挑衅，并非上策。

Lead Villager: I may have lost my temper, but I've put up with them and their shoddy treatment for far too long to care about the consequences! If they fight, then we fight!
乡民首领：我那也是一时心急！要打就打，忍他们许久，谁管得了那么多!

Cheng Heguang: And if you'd made the first move, you'd have been deemed the primary culprit. Were someone to die, your punishment would be death.
程和光：你先动手，便是殴斗的主犯。如果出了人命，主犯可是要判斩刑。

Lead Villager: And what of it?! You think I fear death?! Hah!
乡民首领：那又如何！不过就是死，我难道怕吗!

Lead Villager: The way you speak—it's obvious you come from noble stock. How could someone like you understand our struggles?
乡民首领：你这人说话文绉绉的……想必也是官宦子弟，怎么会懂我们的苦?

The disjointed back-and-forth frays Chéng's patience.
错位榫卯般的对话让程和光有些烦躁。

Cheng Heguang: I'm not—
程和光： 我并非——

During their exchange, several village guards rush over, stirring up a cloud of yellow dust under the Paifang.
谈话间，几位保丁疾奔而来，在牌坊下扬起一阵土黄色的烟尘。

Headman: What's going on here?!
保长： 出了什么事！

Master Hú's personal guards hurry forward to greet them, directing their accusations at the villagers sitting cross-legged by the gate.
家丁们连忙上前招呼，指责在门外盘腿而坐的乡民。

Stern Guard: It's these troublemakers! They've dirtied Master Hú's steps!
严肃的家丁： 就是这些人闹事！弄脏了朝奉的台阶。

Calm Villager: We didn't mean to cause trouble. Someone was mauled by a tiger and urgently needed treatment!
冷静的乡民： 我们不是蓄意闹事，只是因为有人被恶虎咬伤，急需医治！

Headman: Another tiger attack? We've lost three people this month to those beasts!
保长： 老虎？这个月都因为老虎死了三个人了！

Headman: We have warned you over and over not to travel into the mountains. Why go up there?
保长： 乡里三令五申不许进山，你们怎么还上去?

Lead Villager: With this year's feeble harvest, what choice did we have? Five years ago it was floods, and now it's drought! Grain has grown more expensive than gold!
乡民首领： 还不是因为今年收成不好。五年前发洪水，今年又旱，粮价比金子还贵！

Lead Villager: If we don't hunt, what are we to eat?
乡民首领： 不打猎，我们吃西北风吗！

Calm Villager: My land has all been taken, and we have no grain stored for the winter. Hunting rabbits is the only way we can scrape together a half-decent meal.
冷静的乡民： 我家的地都被并了，冬天没存粮，猎只兔子还能凑合一餐……

Disheartened Villager: If only ... If only an immortal would appear again, as they did five years ago, handing out grain to us all.
沮丧的乡民： 就是……要是和五年前一样，有仙人撒粮米就好了……

After a moment's hesitation, Chéng steps past the village guards and offers the headman a modest bow.
程和光犹豫片刻，绕过保丁，走到保长面前，轻作了一揖。

Cheng Heguang: I've had some formal weapons training, including hand-to-hand. If you aim to head into the mountains to hunt the tiger, I will offer my assistance.
程和光： 我学过些拳脚刀法。如果几位要上山打虎，我可以从旁协助。

The village guards exchange amused glances.
保丁们互相看了眼，好像是听着了什么好笑的事情。

Headman: That mountain forest isn't meant for travel. Only a fool would go there without a good reason. Had these hunters not been so greedy, this wouldn't have happened.
保长： 那山林并非官道，平日并无行人。若不是这几个猎户贪吃，怎么会被咬伤?

Headman: The tiger attacked them in the forest, not the village. We can't go traipsing into the forest hunting tigers. We'd never get any real work done!
保长：恶虎也没跑到乡里来肆虐行凶。若是山林里每只老虎都要打，我们还做不做其他事了?!

With a dismissive wave, he turns back to scold the grime-covered villagers.
保长对着他摆了摆手，回身责骂这几个灰头土脸的乡民。

Headman: That's enough! Go back to your homes! And no one is to go up the mountain again!
保长：还不快散了！不许再上山了！

Cheng Heguang: Your decree doesn't change the fact that these hunters still have families to feed.
程和光：话虽如此，可猎户毕竟要养家糊口。

Cheng Heguang: That tiger has taken too many lives. It cannot be ignored.
程和光：那老虎伤了这么多性命，决不能放着不管——

The headman suddenly swings his staff as if he were swatting at an annoying mosquito. Its tip brushes inches from the hem of Chéng's clothes.
保长骤然挥棍擦过程和光的衣摆，仿佛在驱赶一只恼人的蚊虫。

Headman: You're getting on my last nerve, boy!
保长：你这人真烦！

Headman: You are neither an official nor a member of this village. What good does it serve you to stick your nose into our business?
保长：你既非官吏，也不是乡民，管这闲事做什么?

Headman: If you're so eager to play the hero, go deal with the tiger yourself.
保长：你要逞英雄，就自己去打！

Broken cries echo from the courtyard. Chéng tightens his grip on the hilt of his blade.
院内传来断断续续的哀嚎，程和光握紧了刀柄。

Cheng Heguang: This is absurd.
程和光：荒谬。

He pushes past the guards, once again placing himself between them and the villagers.
他推开全副武装的保丁们，又一次挡在乡民中间。

Headman: Hey! What do you think you're doing?!
保长：你干什么，喂！

Cheng Heguang: The tiger. Can you tell me exactly where you encountered it?
程和光：你们在哪里遇见了老虎？可有确定的位置?

Mountaintop, Riverside Village
水乡·山顶

Cheng Heguang: Enter the forest and head due south. After passing another slope, it is somewhere near the edge of the cliff.
程和光：进了林子，一直往南走。再过一个土坡，到靠近崖边的地方。

Cheng Heguang: They said the tiger is blue and white, two or three times larger than an ordinary one. It almost sounds like a monster.
程和光：他们说这只老虎是蓝白色的，比寻常的虎大了两三倍，甚至有点像妖怪。

Ahead stretches a thick pine forest with shrubs reaching up to the knee. Wild grass lies flattened in the undergrowth, streaked with dull, rust-red blood.
眼前是一片茂盛的松林，灌木丛已长至人膝。丛中野草倒伏，依稀可见锈红血迹。

Cheng Heguang: This is where the hunter was wounded. I should proceed with caution.
程和光：这里就是猎户受伤的地方……需得小心。

The forest wind falls silent, and the wild grass rustles softly.
程和光：林间的风停了，野草窸窣作响。

The sound of heavy breathing reaches Chéng's ears.
程和光：沉重的喘息声传入程和光耳中。

Cheng Heguang: It's sneaked behind me!
程和光：在后面！

A massive tiger, blue streaks in its magnificent white fur, bursts from the grass, slamming Chéng to the ground.
巨大的白虎猛然从草中扑出，程和光未及躲闪，便被压倒在地。

He braces his half-drawn blade across his chest, barely holding off the attack.
出鞘一半的长刀被他横在胸前，勉强抵住这次攻击。

Blue flames flare across the tiger's brow as it presses its claws against the blade.
老虎额前烧着蓝色的火焰，仍将前掌压在刀上，不肯放弃这场角斗。

Tiger: *roar*
老虎：吼——

Cheng Heguang: That's some strength, hah!
程和光：好大力气——哈！

A feather shoots from his shoulder guard like an arrow, piercing the tiger's forehead.
肩甲上的一片飞羽如箭般脱出，直刺入老虎的额头。

Tiger: Graaargh!
老虎：嗷呜——

A thunderous roar shakes the forest. In an attempt to escape, the tiger clamps its jaws around Chéng's blade and hauls him forward.
洪亮的吼叫声震得林间树木一抖。老虎吃了痛，癫狂地咬住了程和光的长刀，拖着他奔跑挣扎。

Chéng refuses to let go as the tiger barrels forward, rushing them both to a nearby cliff edge.
程和光亦不肯松手，混乱中竟被老虎一起往崖边拖去。

Cheng Heguang: No!
程和光：不好！

As the tiger leaps, a sudden sense of weightlessness comes over Chéng.
老虎一跃摔出了崖外，失重感骤然摄住了他。

In a split second, he grabs hold of the cliff edge, his body dangling below.
电光石火间，程和光一把扒住崖边，整个身子都已经悬空。

Cheng Heguang: Urgh!
程和光：呃……！

One, two, three ... Feather after feather pierces downward.
一片、两片、三片……更多的飞羽向下刺去。

With the final impact, the tiger's grip loosens. It lets out a final howl as it plummets down into the ravine below and vanishes out of sight.
老虎终于松口，哀嚎着摔下了崖底，直至消失不见。

Cheng Heguang: Phew!
程和光：呼……

Cheng Heguang: The soil is too loose. It needs to be harder if I'm to pull myself up.
程和光：这泥土不牢固，要支撑我翻上去，需要更坚硬些。

Cheng Heguang: Breathe. Sense the flow of Qi. Wherever it touches, the earth hardens like iron.
程和光：感受气的流向……气能触及的地方，即可化为金石。

Cheng Heguang: Concentrate ...
程和光：我应该记得……

The soil beneath his fingers takes on a faint metallic sheen but doesn't spread any further.
指下的泥土泛出了淡淡的金属色泽，但却难以更进一步。

Cheng Heguang: Is it too much for me to handle?
程和光：太大了吗……

Cheng Heguang: ...!
程和光：……！

As the soil's binding begins to fail, the clump in his grip begins to break apart.
失去了泥土的黏性，他所着力的土块已接近断裂。

A pale fog blankets the foot of the cliff. Falling would surely mean his demise.
崖下是一片白蒙蒙的雾气，若是滚落，定是凶多吉少。

Even so, he feels his grip beginning to falter.
但他已经无法支撑。

Cheng Heguang: Darn it!
程和光：可恶……！

A heartbeat before his fingers give out, a thin silver thread slices through the air from the cliff edge.
此时，一根笔直细长的银线从崖边弹出，破空而来。

Cheng Heguang: That's—!
程和光：这是——！

旧友
The Old Friend CH34701-03

Mountaintop, Riverside Village
水乡·山顶

The silver thread coils around Chéng's waist and drags him back onto the cliff.
银线缠住程和光的腰腹，把他卷回崖上。

He hits the ground and rolls, the stabbing pain in his left leg catching up to him on impact.
他摔落在地，滚了两圈，这才迟迟地感受到左腿的刺痛——

A broken branch is lodged in his calf.
一截短木枝横插在他的小腿里。

The village doctor stands over him, calmly reeling the silver thread back onto a bone shuttle.
而那有过一面之缘的秀郎中正站在他面前，将银线重新收入手里的骨梭子。

Cheng Heguang: It's you!
程和光：是你?

Doctor Xiu: Playing the lone hero isn't a healthy habit.
秀郎中：一个人逞英雄，可不是个好习惯。

Cheng Heguang: It's how I usually get things done.
程和光：我只是习惯一个人做事。

Cheng Heguang: Someone had to resolve the matter. Agh. Besides, once I see a problem, I cannot turn a blind eye to it.
程和光：这件事总要有人解决。我既然看见了，就不能置之不理。

Cheng Heguang: I couldn't involve those hunters again, not after they scarcely made it back alive.
程和光：那些猎户刚刚虎口脱险，总不能再叫上他们。

Doctor Xiu: How can you be so sure they wouldn't have lent a hand?
秀郎中：你又怎么知道他们不会帮你?

Doctor Xiù steps closer, squatting down and inspecting the wound on his left leg.
秀郎中靠近几步，蹲下查看他左腿上的伤势。

Doctor Xiu: Good news: it doesn't appear too deep.
秀郎中：还好，应该不深。

Doctor Xiu: Are you ready?
秀郎中：准备好了没?

She doesn't wait for an answer. In one swift motion, she yanks the branch free, and the wound wells with blood.
她并未等待程和光回答，直接把那木枝拔出，留下咕嘟冒血的伤口。

Cheng Heguang: Tch.
程和光：嘶……

Satisfied there are no splinters left in the wound, Doctor Xiù guides her silver thread through a series of precise sutures.
见伤口中并无木屑残留，秀郎中操纵银线，迅速完成了细密的缝合。

With practiced ease, she applies herbs pulled from her robes to the wound, then cuts and ties a clean white bandage.
她利落地从怀里取出草药，涂抹伤口，又剪了一段用于包扎的白布。

Cheng Heguang: Thank you. You've quite the unique method for treating wounds.
程和光：多谢。郎中的医术倒是别有风格。

Doctor Xiu: Ah, I just find some joy in experimenting with my arcane skill.
秀郎中：我只是喜欢研究自己的神秘术。

Cheng Heguang: ...
程和光：……

Cheng Heguang: Forgive my bluntness, but what are you doing here, Doctor?
程和光：郎中怎会来此?

Doctor Xiu: The Hú family refused to let the hunter stay after I patched him up, so I had him taken to my clinic. Whether he survives or not is in fate's hands now.
秀郎中：哦，我刚刚给那猎户处理完。胡家非不许那人留下，我只好让他们抬到我的医馆去。不一定能活，看他运气。

Doctor Xiu: In any case, it struck me that you looked somewhat familiar.
秀郎中：总之，我处理完，忽然想起你有点儿眼熟。

Doctor Xiu: I asked around where you'd gone and was promptly informed that you'd inquired about the tiger's whereabouts and run off alone. To face the beast, no doubt.
秀郎中：然后我就问别人你去哪里了。他们说你问了老虎的位置，就一个人跑了。大概是去打虎了?

Doctor Xiu: "That can't be!" I told them, but their faces were deadly serious. I was worried something might happen, so I hurried over.
秀郎中：我说怎么可能！但他们不像开玩笑的样子。我怕出事，就赶过来了。

Doctor Xiù falls silent, her eyes lingering on Chéng.
秀郎中停住嘴，幽幽地看了程和光一眼。

Doctor Xiu: If not for your lack of familiarity with the terrain, your getting lost notwithstanding, I doubt I'd have been able to catch up to you in time.
秀郎中：幸好你不熟悉这里的地形，迷路了些时候。不然我可能赶不上了。

Cheng Heguang: It wasn't all that dangerous, although the tiger was fiercer than I had anticipated.
程和光：……本没什么危险，只是那老虎比我想得更凶猛。

Doctor Xiu: Hah, the recklessness of youth.
秀郎中：哈，年轻人就是轻狂。

Doctor Xiu: May I know your name?
秀郎中：你怎么称呼?

Cheng Heguang: Chéng Héguāng.
程和光：程和光。

Doctor Xiu: I must say, Chéng Héguāng, that flying-feather technique of yours is quite curious. A skill passed down through your family, I presume?
秀郎中：我看你那飞羽的技艺很新奇，是家传的神秘术?

Cheng Heguang: That's right.
程和光：……是。

Doctor Xiù's winding of the bandage falters for an instant before she finishes up and knots it.
秀郎中包扎的手停顿了一下，接着又若无其事地打了个结。

Doctor Xiu: I once knew a man by the name of Chéng. He commanded flying metal shards through the air. His abilities were quite impressive.
秀郎中：我以前也认识这么个人，姓程，金属片飞来飞去，神秘术蛮厉害……

Doctor Xiu: Still, those who excel in such things tend to have weaker constitutions.
秀郎中：不过神秘术厉害的人，身子骨都会弱点。

Doctor Xiu: He used to be on the wrong side of the law, but "official" was written into both his name and his fate. And sure enough, in the end, he became one.
秀郎中：他本来是道上的，名里带官，命里带官，后来真成了个官咧。

Doctor Xiu: Did you know him?
秀郎中：你认识吗?

Chéng clenches his teeth, his focus shifting to the remaining flying feathers on his shoulder.
肩上还剩了几片飞羽，程和光咬了咬牙。

Cheng Heguang: I can see you've discerned it already. He was my father.
程和光：你既然如此询问，想必心中已有猜测。他是我父亲。

Finished with the bandaging, Doctor Xiù stands up and dusts off her hands.
秀郎中包扎完毕，站起来拍了拍手。

Doctor Xiu: Oh! Well, that's quite the coincidence!
秀郎中：哦！那可巧了！

Doctor Xiu: Your father and I were friends. Which, I suppose, makes you my nephew, or near enough.
秀郎中：我是你父亲的朋友，你也算我的贤侄了。

Doctor Xiu: So listen, nephew: this injury will take a few days to heal, and the dressing will need changing. My clinic is at the foot of the mountain. Come stay with me for a few days.
秀郎中：贤侄啊，这伤口要养几天，中间还要换药。我的医馆就在山脚，你来住几天吧。

Cheng Heguang: Thank you.
程和光：……多谢。

Cheng Heguang: I brought little money with me. I'm afraid I may not have enough to cover the medical expenses for the next few days.
程和光：我这次出门，并未带多少钱。这几日的药钱——

Doctor Xiu: You think I'm after a few coins? Just stay. You can pay me back by lending me your hand when you can.
秀郎中：难道我贪你那仨瓜俩枣？住着就是了！闲时帮我做点活。

Doctor Xiu: Might I lend you mine in getting up?
秀郎中：我扶你?

Cheng Heguang: No need. I can manage.
程和光：不必了。我能走。

Doctor Xiu: The two set off together down the mountain.
秀郎中：二人磕磕绊绊，结伴下山。

Doctor Xiu: You seem young. Are you still studying, or have you already become an official?
秀郎中：你看起来年岁不大，还在读书？还是做官了？

Cheng Heguang: Neither. I mostly get by on odd jobs.
程和光：都没有。平日只做些杂活。

Doctor Xiu: And what "odd job" brought you to this poor place in the middle of nowhere?
秀郎中：怎么跑到这穷乡僻壤?

Cheng Heguang: I was running an errand for someone and happened to pass through.
程和光：替人跑腿，恰巧路过。

Doctor Xiu: I see. How is your mother?
秀郎中：你母亲可好?

Cheng Heguang: Well enough.
程和光：……还好。

Doctor Xiu: Hmm. And your father?
秀郎中：唔……你父亲也还好?

Cheng Heguang: He passed away.
程和光：……他去世了。

Doctor Xiu: What happened?
秀郎中：……怎么回事?

Cheng Heguang: He had an accident.
程和光：意外。

Doctor Xiu: I'm sorry. I never would have imagined.
秀郎中：抱歉，我没想到。

Cheng Heguang: Imagined?
程和光：没想到?

Doctor Xiu: Mhm. He was still young. But, I suppose death comes for us all.
秀郎中：嗯，他还年轻。不过生老病死，本是常事。

A long silence falls.
程和光：一时无人再说话。

Foot of Mountain, Riverside Village
水乡·山脚

Reaching the foot of the mountain, they push through the grass and follow the stream for a short distance.
他们回到山脚，穿过草丛，沿着溪流走了几十步。

From between the trees, a solitary white house emerges into view.
树木掩映之间，倏然出现了一座孤零零的白房子。

Cheng Heguang: Why set up a clinic out here in the wilderness? It would be easier to see patients if you lived in the village.
程和光：为何独自在此开设医馆？住在乡里，出诊会更方便。

Doctor Xiu: Convenient, sure. But the houses in the village are tall and crammed together one after another. Living like that would be maddening.
秀郎中：是方便。但那乡里房子又高又窄，一间挤一间，住着要憋死人。

Cheng Heguang: But your clinic has the same black roof tiles and white walls. It looks no different from the houses in Zhu County or the village.
程和光：可是，郎中的医馆也是青瓦白墙……看着与祝县、水乡的房子并无二致。

Doctor Xiu: What do you expect me to do, paint the house black from top to bottom?
秀郎中：难道我还能把房子刷成黑的吗——

Doctor Xiù whirls, sending three silver threads like spider silk toward Chéng's vital joints.
秀郎中忽然回身，手中三条银线如蛛丝般袭向程和光的关节要处。

As if he'd anticipated the attack, Chéng dodges. Flying feathers clash with silver threads, tangling as they fall to the ground.
程和光敏捷避开，似乎早有准备；飞羽与银线交击，缠斗掉落。

Cheng Heguang: What was that?!
程和光：你这是何意?!

Doctor Xiu: Ah, you could have stood and taken the threads, yet you chose to dodge and tear the wound open instead.
秀郎中：唉，明明可一步不动，偏偏就要腾挪躲闪，撕裂伤口。

Cheng Heguang: ...?
程和光：……?

Doctor Xiu: Your command over your arcane skill is undisciplined, to say the least. Had you used it properly earlier, you'd have subdued the tiger without so much as a scratch.
秀郎中：你的神秘术怎么用得如此不像样？若是用好了，之前便可轻松制服老虎，怎会受伤?

Doctor Xiù shakes her head and sighs.
秀郎中频频摇头，唉声叹气。

Doctor Xiu: I remember how your father would turn leaves to metal, sending them flying as he bid. There are plenty of leaves here. Why not give it a try?
秀郎中：我记得当年程小弟可将叶子化作金属飞出，这里枝叶繁茂，你何不试试?

Cheng Heguang: ...
程和光：……

Cheng Heguang: I can't.
程和光：我不会。

Cheng Heguang: Everyone from my clan can control light metals, but transmutation ... I am the only one left who can do it. Or at least, I ought to be.
程和光：族人虽然都能操纵轻量金属，但这化金的能力……如今除我之外无人掌握。

Doctor Xiu: You've chosen not to use this unique ability?
秀郎中：你不愿意用?

Cheng Heguang: Not exactly.
程和光：……不是。

Cheng Heguang: I can no longer control it, as if something is blocking me. As a child, I used it recklessly. It caused an accident. After that, with no one to guide me, I dared not use it often.
程和光：这能力不好控制，幼时贪玩出过祸事。之后无人教习，不敢多用。

Doctor Xiu: A waste, if you ask me. Only you possess this ability, and yet you shackle yourself with hesitation.
秀郎中：既然有这个能力，又何必自缚手脚?

Doctor Xiu: Your father and I sparred many times, enough for me to become familiar with his arcane skill.
秀郎中：我与程小弟对练多次，也算熟悉他的神秘术。

Doctor Xiu: His arcane skill, like mine, relied on guiding matter with Qi. If you wish it, I can teach you a few techniques. Be a guide of sorts.
秀郎中：我们的神秘术都是以气控物，不如我来教你几招。

Cheng Heguang: But why?
程和光：……为何?

Doctor Xiu: Why? Because I want to, and because it's the right thing to do.
秀郎中：什么为何，因为我乐意。而且，这也是我该做的。

Cheng Heguang: But ...
程和光：不——

Doctor Xiu: Chéng Héguāng, when an elder offers you her teachings, you shut your mouth and listen.
秀郎中：前辈指点，听着就行了!

Main Room, Clinic
水乡·医馆正房

Doctor Xiù swings open the clinic door without ceremony.
秀郎中大剌剌地推开了医馆的大门。

Inside the clinic, an assistant is busy boiling medicine. Two or three patients lie resting nearby, including the hunter whose arm was mauled earlier.
医馆里有个忙着煮药的伙计，另外躺着两三个病人，包括之前那被咬伤手臂的猎户。

Assistant: Doctor, you're back! Who's this?
伙计：大姐，你回来了！这位是——?

Doctor Xiu: A patient I picked up on the road. How's the hunter?
秀郎中：路上遇着的病人。那猎户怎么样了?

Assistant: He's still unconscious.
伙计：还昏着。

Doctor Xiu: Alright. Be sure to change his dressing in a couple of hours and keep a close eye on him tonight. A fever could prove fatal.
秀郎中：嗯，过两个时辰换药。夜间看好了，千万别烧起来，那就危险了。

One of the patients, a young man, hops out of bed and runs over, his face flushed with color.
一个年轻人跳下床，满面红光地跑过来。

Young Man: Doctor! That medicine's incredible! I've never felt so alive, like I could plow two acres of land without so much as a breath!
青年人：郎中！那药真好用！我今天浑身都是力气，感觉还能耕两亩地！

Doctor Xiu: I'm glad to hear—
秀郎中：那就好——

Old Man: Doctor! Help! Help!
老年人：郎中！救命啊！救命啊！

Doctor Xiù lets out a weary sigh and walks over to the old man's bed.
秀郎中叹口气，走到哀嚎不止的老人榻前。

Doctor Xiu: What is it this time?
秀郎中：又怎么了？

Old Man: I still feel terribly ill. My stomach hurts, and I throw up every time I eat.
老年人：我还是恶心，肚子疼，吃了东西就吐……

Doctor Xiu: I gave you strict instructions not to have any food! But you just couldn't help yourself, could you?
秀郎中：说了禁食！说了禁食！谁让你吃东西了！就缺这一口吗？

Assistant: Uh. I've just brewed him some fresh medicine. I only poured it a moment ago. It's still hot.
伙计：……我给他新熬了药，刚倒出来，还烫着。

Doctor Xiu: To the assistant's surprise, Doctor Xiù smiles and looks up at Chéng, who is still standing by the door.
秀郎中：秀郎中忽然笑了，抬头看向仍站在门口的程和光。

Doctor Xiu: Perfect. We have just the man for handling a little heat.
秀郎中：正好，我们有个不怕烫的。

Cheng Heguang: ...?
程和光：……？

碎玉
The Silver Thread CH34701-04

Doctor Xiu: Now, Chéng, move the bowl of medicine on the table into my hand using only your family's technique.
秀郎中：把台上那碗药挪到我手里——用神秘术。

Cheng Heguang: Why?
程和光：为何？

Doctor Xiu: Do you often make a habit of arguing with your elders?
秀郎中：贤侄啊，怎么总是和长辈顶嘴呢？

Cheng Heguang: ...
程和光：……

Doctor Xiu: Brewing and serving medicine is part of the clinic's duties. But, if you'd prefer to lie around and take advantage of my hospitality for the next few days, be my guest.
秀郎中：熬药端药，也算是医馆的活计。你要是想白躺几天，那也随你！

Chéng falls silent for a moment, then extends his right hand and aims it at the bowl of medicine.
程和光沉默片刻，伸出右手，对准那药碗。

Cheng Heguang: Urgh. Hngh!
程和光：唔……呃……

In an instant, the medicine bowl turns black and spins forward, almost crashing into Doctor Xiù's hand.
程和光：药碗瞬间变了黑色，几乎是飞旋着撞进了秀郎中的手心。

Doctor Xiu: Hmm. A little excessive, but all in all, not bad for a first try.
秀郎中：嗯……距离正常，但力度太大。

Doctor Xiu: Although, it is rather heavy. I wonder why.
秀郎中：怎么这么重，我看看……

Doctor Xiu: Hahahaha!
秀郎中：哈哈哈哈哈哈哈！

She breaks into a cheerful laugh, then props the metal bowl upright and shows it to Chéng.
她忽然爆发出一阵愉快的大笑，随后把铁碗竖立起来，展示给程和光看。

The medicinal broth inside the bowl has been transmuted along with it, becoming a solid block of metal.
原来药汤也被一起变为了金属，成了实打实的铁块。

Doctor Xiu: Fortunately, the effect wears off in time; otherwise, you'd be paying for the medicine.
秀郎中：幸好这术法一炷香便能恢复原状，不然你可要赔我一碗药。

Doctor Xiu: Have patience. Remember, a single day does not make a master.
秀郎中：你稍等等吧。

Old Man: Owww!
老年人：呃啊！

Cheng Heguang: It's been a long while since I've used it so much.
程和光：……我许久未用了。

Cheng Heguang: With a little more practice, I know I will perform it without error.
程和光：只要多练习几次，定可以完美使出。

Doctor Xiù retrieves several chipped, broken bowls from around the room.
秀郎中四处转了几圈，不知从哪里收拾出一堆缺口的破碗。

Doctor Xiu: Well, you're not lacking for confidence. Why not begin with these? Once you've mastered them, lighter things like flowers and leaves should be no problem at all.
秀郎中：先用这些东西练吧。练好了这些，更轻的花叶不在话下。

Doctor Xiu: Your arcane skill works much like my own, simple, really. Sense the flow of Qi, carefully straighten it, and aim it at the object.
秀郎中：“锐意”与我的神秘术类似，无非是个绣花的技巧。细细理好你感受到的气，对准那东西——

Doctor Xiu: And strike.
秀郎中：然后刺下。

Cheng Heguang: Hyah!
程和光：哈！

The metal bowl slams into the wall once again, and Chéng's brow knots even tighter.
铁碗又一次砸在了白墙上，程和光的眉头拧得更深了些。

Hunter: Young man, I have watched you throw that broken bowl around day after day, and I still can't fathom why Doctor Xiù is making you do it.
猎户：小哥，我看你天天在摔这个破碗。也不知道秀郎中为何要你做这个？

Having woken up with little else to occupy him, the tiger-bitten hunter has decided to strike up a conversation with Chéng.
之前被虎咬伤的猎户已经苏醒。他闲来无事，主动和程和光攀谈起来。

Cheng Heguang: I'm training my arcane skill.
程和光：是训练我神秘术的方法。

Unable to resist, the remaining two bedridden patients chime in as well.
另外两个躺在床上的病人，也忍不住加入了对话。

Old Man: Training? That old lady can't even throw a punch. What, does she think she's some sort of martial arts master now?
老年人：训练？她一个不会拳脚的老婆婆，竟当起教头来了！

Cheng Heguang: What do you mean "can't throw a punch"?
程和光：不会拳脚？

Young Man: Haha! Did she catch you off guard too?
青年人：哈哈，你是不是也被她吓住了！

Young Man: She looks fierce, has a bad temper, and talks loud enough to rattle the bedpans, but I've never once seen Doctor Xiù get into a fight with anyone.
青年人：秀郎中是长得凶了点，脾气臭了些，说话声音大了些——可从没见过她和人打过架。

Old Man: Her arcane skill, those silver threads of hers, is finer than hair. Other than stitching up wounds, what good could they be?
老年人：她那神秘术，没根头发丝粗的银线，能干什么？也就是缝缝伤口。

Cheng Heguang: The thought hadn't occurred to me.
程和光：……这倒是没想到。

Hunter: Come now, you can hardly say that! At the Dushuo Festival, Doctor Xiù played a female soldier, remember? "Kill! Kill!" She was like a demoness, fierce as anything!
猎户：你可别这么说！那年度朔，秀郎中不是还演了个什么娘子军，在那喊：杀！杀！可有气势了！

Young Man: Come on, anyone can shout! I could just as well play a great general! "All troops, heed my command!"
青年人：嗨呀，喊喊谁不会？我还能演大将军呢，三军听令——

Another metal bowl rolls onto the floor.
又一个铁碗滚落在地。

Cheng Heguang: Still, I hear there was once a bandit in Huanzhou who fought with silver threads.
程和光：……可我听说，涣州以前有个匪徒，也是用银线做武器。

Cheng Heguang: They say the bandit stole state supplies, torched villages, and left many soldiers wounded.
程和光：劫过官粮，烧过村子，伤了不少官兵。

Old Man: I've heard traveling merchants talk about the very same thing. They say those silver threads could cut through iron like mud. Frightening stuff.
老年人：这事我倒是听外头的商贩说过，说那银线削铁如泥，厉害得很。

Old Man: In the end, the bandit raided Zhu County. But, after that, word of them vanished.
老年人：最后是进了祝县抢劫不是？之后就没听说了。

Young Man: Zhu County?! That's the richest place in all of Huanzhou! All manner of merchants and officials live there.
青年人：祝县！那可是涣州最富庶的县，里面住着不少商贾和高官亲戚！

Young Man: Not like this poor backwater town we're stuck in.
青年人：和咱们这穷地方不一样……

Hunter: Nonsense! Doctor Xiù would never stoop to being some lowly mountain bandit! If she could fight, she'd be a hero!
猎户：你们这都是胡说！秀郎中就算会打架，也肯定是个大侠，怎么会是山贼呢?

Young Man: Plenty of people have similar arcane skills, don't they? I can produce flames from my fingertips, just like the Hú family!
青年人：不同人也会有相似的神秘术吧，我还和胡家人一样，都能指尖打火苗呢！

Old Man: I suppose you're right. I've never seen her use those silver threads for anything practical, not even to slice a vegetable. Perhaps they simply aren't good for much!
老年人：是啊，都没见她拿银线切过菜，估计真没啥用！

Hunter: You could walk every street of the village saying she's a bandit, and I bet not a soul would believe it.
猎户：你说她做过什么贼，全水乡都没人信的。

Cheng Heguang: Is that so?
程和光：是吗……

Old Man: There was a time we didn't have a doctor in the village. Small illnesses, we just had to endure, and we couldn't afford the county fees for anything serious.
老年人：咱们乡以前是没医生的，小病都得忍着，大病跑到县里也交不起诊费药钱。

Old Man: After Doctor Xiù arrived, the villagers could finally get the treatment they needed.
老年人：几年前，秀郎中来了，乡里人才看得起病了。

Young Man: That's right. My son was having convulsions last year. It's thanks to her that he's still with us.
青年人：就是，我儿子去年惊厥，还多亏了她救命。

Cheng Heguang: ...
程和光：……

The metal bowl slowly rises, wobbling as it drifts toward the other side of the room.
铁碗缓慢升起，摇晃着飞向另一边。

Finally, it settles smoothly on the table.
——最终平稳地落到了桌上。

Cheng Heguang: ...!
程和光：……！

Hunter: Well done, young man! It's about time you finally managed it!
猎户：哎哟，小哥你可真厉害！可算是成了！

Old Man: Now maybe you can get my medicine over here without spilling it!
老年人：这下可以把我的药平安拿来了！

Doctor Xiu: Ah, the Hú family's calling me over for medicine again! Ever sending their orders, yet never bothering to actually come to the clinic!
秀郎中：哎，胡家又要我去开药！呼来喝去的，都不肯屈尊来医馆！

Doctor Xiu: I swear, the day I end up saving their lives is the day I squeeze ten thousand taels out of them!
秀郎中：如果我哪天救了他们的命，非要敲诈一万两不可！

Assistant: Go ahead, Doctor. I'll keep an eye on the clinic.
伙计：知道了，你去吧。医馆有我看着。

Doctor Xiù is halfway across the threshold when a teacup suddenly spins in from behind, aimed at her side.
秀郎中正欲迈过门槛，一只茶杯却忽然从侧后方飞旋砸来。

Assistant: Doctor!
伙计：大姐！

Doctor Xiù doesn't even flinch. She reaches out her hand, and the teacup halts in midair before slowly dropping into her palm.
秀郎中并不惊慌，只是对着茶杯伸出手掌。那茶杯也真就立刻停住势头，缓缓落在她手中。

The cup's base gleams with a clean metallic sheen. The tea inside is perfectly brewed, the leaves fully unfurled and settled at the bottom.
杯底的圈足变成了漂亮的金属色，杯中是泡好的清茶，茶叶已完全舒展，沉在水底。

Cheng Heguang: So?
程和光：如何?

Doctor Xiu: To have come this far in just three days! Your progress is indeed worthy of praise.
秀郎中：三日便能如此，的确值得夸奖。

Doctor Xiù drains the tea in one gulp, then steps out the door.
秀郎中将茶水一饮而尽，出门离开。

Side Room, Clinic
水乡·医馆偏房

In the early hours of the morning, while the patients are still sleeping, Chéng Héguāng gathers the broken bowls together.
时辰尚早，病人们仍在睡觉。程和光将那些破碗挪到另一间屋子，打算一并收拾了。

The doctor's assistant walks over carrying a bowl of medicinal broth.
伙计端着一碗药汤走过来。

Assistant: Time for your medicine, young man.
伙计：小哥，该喝药了。

Cheng Heguang: Hm? I don't recall Doctor Xiù prescribing me any additional medication.
程和光：我并无内服药物。

Assistant: It's a new prescription, designed to help replenish your Qi.
伙计：是新开的，补气。

Cheng Heguang: Smells like Huangqi and Danggui. But my injury is already healed. There's no use wasting good medicine.
程和光：……闻起来像黄芪、当归。但我的伤已经好了，没必要浪费。

Assistant: You still need to make up for your Qi and blood loss. The doctor specially prescribed it for you.
伙计：损耗的气血也要补回来的，这可是郎中特意安排的。

Chéng frowns slightly but still takes the medicine and raises it to his lips.
程和光：程和光微微皱眉，还是接过了药，举到嘴边。

A silver thread shoots in and knocks the medicine bowl from his hand.
一根银线飞来，打翻了他手里的药碗。

It shatters with a sharp crack. Brown medicinal liquid splashes across the floor.
瓷碗发出清脆的碎裂声，棕色的药液溅了满地。

Doctor Xiù stands nearby with a hardened expression.
秀郎中沉着脸站在不远处。

Doctor Xiu: That is not what I prescribed.
秀郎中：那不是他的药。

Assistant: Doctor! You've returned already?!
伙计：大姐！你怎么回来了！

Doctor Xiu: I came back for something. What's going on here?
秀郎中：回来拿东西。这怎么回事?

Assistant: This new patient of yours, he's up to something.
伙计：……是他别有所图。

The assistant pulls a pale yellow sheet of paper from his jacket and hands it to Doctor Xiù.
伙计从衣襟里掏出一张淡黄色的纸，交到秀郎中手中。

Cheng Heguang: Did you go through my bag?!
程和光：你翻了我的包裹?!

Assistant: Regular visitors don't inquire about bandits at a clinic. You covered your tracks well, but not well enough!
伙计：寻常人怎么会在医馆打听什么贼匪？藏得还挺严实，叫我好找！

Doctor Xiu: Let's see here. "The bandit known as 'Shuttlebones,' bearing arms in public, robbed the prefectural granary ..."
秀郎中：哦，我看看……“骨梭子，明火执仗，劫掠府仓。”

Doctor Xiu: "The offender is a violent bandit who wields a bone shuttle and silver thread with deadly precision. All jurisdictions are commanded to conduct the arrest with extreme vigilance."
秀郎中：“此贼凶悍，手持骨梭，擅使银线。现着诸府州县缉之，务必小心周详。”

Doctor Xiu: So this is the warrant for my arrest? My, my, look how hideous this drawing of me is. Who would even recognize me from such a scrawl? I suppose it was my arcane skill that gave me away, wasn't it?
秀郎中：哈哈，这张通缉令我倒没见过。竟然把我画这么丑，这谁能认出来？还是得靠这手神秘术……是不是啊?

Cheng Heguang: ...
程和光：……

Assistant: I'm sorry, Doctor. I wanted to deal with this before you returned.
伙计：我不想牵连大姐，本想偷偷解决——

Doctor Xiù folds the arrest warrant in half and tosses it into the nearby brazier.
秀郎中把通缉令对折，丢到一边的火盆里。

Doctor Xiu: Our curious patient here is Brother Chéng's child.
秀郎中：这是程小弟的小孩。

Assistant: Heh, I had my suspicions with that arcane skill of his.
伙计：呵，我猜到了，那神秘术……

Assistant: But so what if he is?! We helped Chéng Dàoguān when he needed it most. His son ought to help us in return! Besides, you've done nothing wrong!
伙计：但那又如何！程道官是我们看着长大的，本来就应该帮忙！大姐没有错！

Assistant: My daughter was starving to death while he dragged his feet every step of the way, acting the young lord. If it weren't you—
伙计：我女儿都饿死了，他还在那装什么老爷，百般不情愿。说什么拿快些，拿少点，如果不是大姐——

Doctor Xiù slams her palm down on the table beside her.
秀郎中猛地拍了下身旁的桌案。

Doctor Xiu: Enough! There's medicine that needs boiling.
秀郎中：够了！你进去把药熬了。

Doctor Xiu: Go!
秀郎中：去啊！

The assistant casts an unwilling glance at Chéng, then leaves in sullen silence.
伙计不甘地看了程和光一眼，悻悻地走了。

Doctor Xiù suddenly sweeps the metallized broken bowls to the floor.
秀郎中忽而袖袍一挥，将那些化为金属的破碗扫落在地。

Cheng Heguang: ...!
程和光：……！

Doctor Xiu: You said you're not with the Yamen.
秀郎中：你说你不是衙门的人。

Cheng Heguang: I am not. But on occasion, I take bounty orders from them.
程和光：我的确不是。我只是从衙门那里领了追缉的任务。

Doctor Xiu: Ah, your "odd jobs." Is it the money you care for? Or is it something else?
秀郎中：为了钱？还是什么……

Doctor Xiu: Why not confront me directly? Waiting for me to nurse you to health first? Planning to slit my throat in the night?
秀郎中：为何不挑明动手，想等到养好伤再偷袭我？

Cheng Heguang: I've watched you for days. Nothing about you resembles a criminal.
程和光：……我在此观察多日，你的行径不像恶人。

Cheng Heguang: That warrant means nothing to me.
程和光：通缉令也只是一张纸。

Cheng Heguang: If you swear to me that you never committed arson, hurt anyone, or raided Zhu County, then I will leave at once.
程和光：若你未曾纵火伤人，劫掠祝县。我这便离开。

Doctor Xiù draws in a slow breath, her face returning to its usual calm.
秀郎中深吸了一口气，表情归于平淡。

Doctor Xiu: But I did it all.
秀郎中：可惜我做了。

Doctor Xiu: Your injury's healed, hasn't it?
秀郎中：你的伤是不是好了？

Doctor Xiu: Let's get started.
秀郎中：那就打吧。

飞草
The Flying Leaves CH34701-05

Mother: Shuttlebones ... I remember her. She knew your father once.
母亲：骨梭子……我记得是你父亲之前认识的人。

Cheng Heguang: Yes. The Yamen has confirmed she was the ringleader behind the raid on Zhu County that night.
程和光：是。衙门审讯得知，她就是那晚劫掠祝县的主谋。

Cheng Heguang: All those caught in that raid were executed, save for her. She fled with a handful of others, disappearing near the Riverside Village.
程和光：那晚的盗匪都被处决，唯有她带着几个人逃脱，在水乡附近失了踪迹。

Cheng Heguang: If she yet lives after all these years, she has likely lowered her guard and settled into an ordinary life.
程和光：过去这么多年，若她还活着，想必会放松警惕，过上平常的生活。

Cheng Heguang: If I resolve this, I'll have amassed enough merit to fill the opening for the constable. And the reward sum will surely help us in the meantime.
程和光：巡检有个空缺。若我能解决这件事，便有了能填缺的功劳。得了赏钱，也可贴补家用。

Mother: You'll finally have some standing, and those brutes at the Yamen won't push you around any longer. *cough, cough*
母亲：如此，你终于也有了功名，不必给那些人欺负……咳咳。

Mother: Your father told me a little about Shuttlebones before. She is powerful, a reliable ally, and a formidable foe.
母亲：我不熟他那些狐朋狗友。但你父亲提过，她实力强劲，是个可靠的朋友，也是难缠的对手。

Cheng Heguang: I'll be careful. Besides, there are few anywhere in Huanzhou Prefecture who can match the blade techniques you taught me.
程和光：我会小心。何况，母亲传我的刀法在涣州府本就鲜有敌手。

Mother: Haha. That's good to hear.
母亲：哈哈……这话我爱听。

Mother: I worry that you're pushing yourself too hard.
母亲：但我只担心你太过勉强自己。

Chéng takes his sword down from the wall.
程和光从墙上取下长刀。

Cheng Heguang: No need to worry.
程和光：不必担心。

Cheng Heguang: This is what I've always wanted, and it's the only right way forward.
程和光：这正是我一直追求的道路，也是唯一正确的道路。

Foot of Mountain, Riverside Village
水乡·山脚

Amid a clearing in the mountain woods, Chéng stands peering up at the trees.
小路的尽头是一片山林间的空地。程和光站在树下，抬头仰望。

Cheng Heguang: So this is what you meant by a duel?
程和光：这便是你所说的决斗？

Doctor Xiù perches with one leg propped on a tree branch, calmly twirling the bone shuttle in her hand.
秀郎中跷脚坐在一根极高的树枝上，好整以暇地转着手里的骨梭子。

Doctor Xiu: This is how I toyed with Yamen officers when I was young. You should never expect an enemy to fight on your terms.
秀郎中：年轻时，我就是这么遛官兵的。你总不能要求敌人按照你熟悉的方式战斗。

Cheng Heguang: So be it.
程和光：……好。

Chéng draws his blade, cleaving the high branch in a single strike.
程和光抽刀出鞘，猛然横劈高树的枝干。

Doctor Xiu: Hmph. That's what they used to do, too.
秀郎中：这是他们用过的办法。

A silver thread shoots out from the swaying leaves, carrying Doctor Xiù safely to the high branches of another tree.
一根银线从摇晃的枝叶间吐出，将秀郎中安然无恙地荡到另一棵树的高处。

Doctor Xiu: Never worked back then either.
秀郎中：而且失败了。

Chéng sends several leaves shooting upward. They fall short before reaching their mark.
程和光凝视着那段高枝，操控几枚树叶向上刺去。只是它们未及高度，便已唰唰掉落。

Doctor Xiu: You're wasting your energy. I know your arcane skill cannot reach so high.
秀郎中：别白费力气了！我知道你的神秘术够不着这里。

Cheng Heguang: Then I'll drag you back down!
程和光：那便逼你到我能够着的高度！

The sword whirls in his hands, the force trembling the surrounding pines.
长刀在他手里旋风似的劈砍，霎时间便引得周围的松木激荡。

After several moments, Doctor Xiù cannot help but sigh.
几次来回，秀郎中不禁叹了口气。

Doctor Xiu: Ah, you foolish boy. Tell me, what do you believe this will achieve?
秀郎中：唉，小子愚钝！这样又有什么用？

Doctor Xiu: This little thread of mine can go very far. Allow me to demonstrate.
秀郎中：我这线可是能伸半里地——

A longer silver thread extends from her outstretched arm, propelling her toward a distant tree.
一根更长的银线，连向更远的树木。

Doctor Xiu: Hmm?
秀郎中：嗯？

The silver thread snaps, sending her hurtling back to the ground.
银线本应如她所料将她收往高处，却中途崩断，把她甩落在地。

Two metal leaves fall from the air in her wake.
空中两枚铁叶随之落下。

Doctor Xiu: Nicely done.
秀郎中：做得不错。

Cheng Heguang: When you swing between the trees, you lose some height. How much you drop depends on the length of the silver thread.
程和光：你在树间摇荡时，会下落一段距离……下落的多少取决于银线的长度。

Cheng Heguang: No matter how long your thread, my arcane skill will be able to reach you.
程和光：只要你用的银线够长，我的神秘术便能够到你。

Chéng braces his blade before him.
程和光将刀压在身前。

Cheng Heguang: Are you ready to finish this?
程和光：现在打吗?

Doctor Xiù turns her back and begins to amble off along the mountain path.
秀郎中已经背过身去，慢悠悠走上了回程。

Doctor Xiu: No, I'm tired now.
秀郎中：不，我累了。

Chéng stares at her back, confused, before deciding to follow after her.
程和光无可奈何，只得跟上。

Cheng Heguang: If you never meant to fight, why challenge me? Why lure me here?
程和光：你怎可如此耍赖?！若是不想对决，何必主动约战，诳我来此?

Doctor Xiu: Why the hurry? You can't be sure you'll beat me, can you? Ever heard of keeping your blade sheathed and waiting for the perfect moment to strike?
秀郎中：急什么！你还不一定能赢我呢！有个词叫“韬光养晦”，你懂不懂?

Doctor Xiu: And even if you were to win, what then?
秀郎中：若你赢了，要做什么?

Cheng Heguang: I would take you to the Yamen.
程和光：带你去衙门。

Doctor Xiu: The very moment you defeat me?
秀郎中：赢的那天就去?

Cheng Heguang: No. Not until every patient in the clinic is healed.
程和光：……不，等到医馆里的病人都痊愈了。

Doctor Xiu: Then you'll be waiting for a long time! Over a thousand people live in that Riverside Village. Three days don't pass without someone knocking at the door!
秀郎中：那你可指望错了！这水乡一千多人，医馆三天两头有人光顾，可没有清闲的时候！

Doctor Xiu: Besides, there are still some patients in the clinic right now, are there not? So what's the rush? We'll come back to this tomorrow.
秀郎中：何况，医馆现在不还有两个病人吗？那又何必着急？明日再打下一段吧。

The Next Day
翌日

Doctor Xiu: Fallen leaves scatter, turning into metallic blades as they tangle with silver thread.
秀郎中：落叶纷纷化为利刃，与银线缠在一处。

They streak through the air in a blur, impossible to make out.
二者速度极快，化作空中一道道难以辨识的残影。

Doctor Xiu: You're improving quickly. Most struggle to see my thread, let alone defend against it.
秀郎中：你进步很快。一般人可没法全接下我的招式。

Cheng Heguang: Still not fast enough. I can't catch the silver thread's Qi. I can't turn it into metal.
程和光：还不够快。我抓不住银线的气……没法把它变成金属。

Cheng Heguang: You're shielding the bone shuttle in your grip. Its Qi resistance is too strong. I can't properly use my arcane skill.
程和光：骨梭子被你握在手中保护，气的阻滞很强……“锐意”亦不能使用。

Doctor Xiu: I can't allow you to destroy my weapon that quickly. I have a reputation to uphold.
秀郎中：要是让你这么快就废了我的武器，我的名声还要不要了？

Several blackened silver threads coil around the edge of Chéng's blade.
几道黑色的银线缠住了锋利的刀锋。

Doctor Xiu: You rely too much on your arcane skill. Your metallization is irreversible. You've even trapped your own blade.
秀郎中：神秘术也不是次次好用的，对吧？你无法解除金属化，反而束缚了自己的刀。

Cheng Heguang: ...
程和光：……

Doctor Xiu: As the silver thread whips around Chéng's neck, the wild grass beneath Doctor Xiù's feet lashes upward in stabbing arcs.
秀郎中：程和光脖颈上的银线骤然收紧。与此同时，秀郎中脚下的野草倒飞上刺。

Doctor Xiu: The blades of grass halt at her throat.
秀郎中：草叶急停在了她的喉间。

Doctor Xiu: ...!
秀郎中：……！

Doctor Xiu: Handling so many at once. I underestimated you.
秀郎中：能同时控制这么多……倒是小瞧你了。

Cheng Heguang: Urgh. Let's call it a draw.
程和光：呃……平了。

Doctor Xiu: Fine.
秀郎中：好。

Doctor Xiu: We'll stop here for today.
秀郎中：今天就这样吧。

Yard, Clinic
水乡·医馆庭院

After some hours of training in the woods, Chéng returns to the clinic a little late.
程和光在林地里练了些时候，迟了一步返回医馆。

Several villagers are helping the hunter as he heads home. When he spots Chéng, he raises a hand in greeting.
几位乡民正扶着那猎户离开。猎户看见他，朝他招了招手。

Hunter: I'm on the mend and ready to head home. Doctor Xiù has plenty of work to do. Last thing she needs is me taking up more of her time.
猎户：我没什么大事了，回家了！秀郎中事务繁忙，不好总是留在这里麻烦她。

Hunter: I heard you killed that tiger! Why didn't you tell me sooner? I'll head back to the village and let everyone know!
猎户：我知道你把那老虎杀了，怎么不早告诉我！我这就回乡里和大家伙说声！

Cheng Heguang: I only did what was necessary. No need to make a fuss.
程和光：举手之劳，不必如此。

The man doesn't hear a word, only shuffling off with a foolish grin on his face.
对方却全不听他讲话，傻乐着走远了。

Chéng enters the clinic to find Doctor Xiù seated by the medicine stove, gently fanning the flames.
程和光走回医馆，看见秀郎中正坐在药炉边扇风。

A few days earlier, Doctor Xiù sent her assistant to prepare medicine for the Hú household. Now it is only the two of them.
伙计几天前被秀郎中赶去胡家做熬药师傅，如今医馆里只剩他们两人。

Cheng Heguang: With such skills in medicine, why become a bandit?
程和光：……你既然有如此医术，为什么要去做盗匪？

Doctor Xiu: Because I wanted to be a hero.
秀郎中：因为我想做英雄。

Cheng Heguang: Righteous ends must be pursued through righteous means. However they justify it, bandits inevitably bring harm to the innocent.
程和光：大义需在正道上实现。盗匪纵使有劫富济贫之举，也难免会伤害无辜。

Doctor Xiu: There's no reasoning with someone as immovable as you. Distributing the grain I'd stolen from the officials to the poor—that is a life worth living!
秀郎中：与你这正经人说不通。像神仙一样往贫民房子里撒粮，那才叫畅快！

Cheng Heguang: And robbing the people of Zhu County? Is that your idea of heroism?
程和光：……劫掠祝县百姓，也是英雄之举吗？

Doctor Xiù keeps her eyes on the medicine stove, seemingly oblivious to Chéng's words.
秀郎中一心盯着药炉，似乎没有注意程和光说话。

A long silence passes before she replies.
片刻后，她才做了回答。

Doctor Xiu: No. I know I don't have the stuff to be a hero. But, living here and being a doctor respected by the people? That I can do.
秀郎中：不是。所以我知道自己当不成英雄。在这做个人人尊敬的郎中，可是轻松多了。

Doctor Xiu: Tell me, what happened to your father?
秀郎中：你父亲在那件事之后如何了？

Cheng Heguang: You didn't know?
程和光：你不知道？

Doctor Xiu: Sorry, I was running for my life back then, too busy pretending to be something I'm not, hah.
秀郎中：抱歉，我跑得太快，急着当神仙呐，哈哈。

She chuckles with a trace of self-mockery.
她自嘲似的笑了笑。

Doctor Xiu: And after that, well, I settled into a life of black tiles and white walls. Every day filled with the simple chatterings of villagers and patients, knowing nothing of the outside world.
秀郎中：之后，我住在青瓦白墙里面，柴米油盐，布帛菽粟，天天听乡民病人的八卦。其他的一律不知。

Cheng Heguang: I told you he passed away.
程和光：我说过他去世了。

Cheng Heguang: He confessed to his crimes and accepted his punishment.
程和光：所以自然是和其他人一样……认罪伏法。

Doctor Xiu: I see.
秀郎中：……所以是因为这件事。

Doctor Xiu: ...
秀郎中：……

Doctor Xiù lifts the lid of the medicine pot and peers inside. In an instant, the clinic fills with the bitter scent of herbs.
秀郎中提起药炉的盖子，向内看了一眼，整个医馆瞬间溢满了草药的苦香。

Cheng Heguang: The villagers speak so highly of your medical skills. Do you know anything about treating consumption? Any special remedies?
程和光：……乡民都夸你的医术不错，你对痨病可有研究，可有什么灵丹妙药之类?

Doctor Xiu: What are the symptoms? How long has it been?
秀郎中：什么症状，多久了?

Cheng Heguang: It began the winter before last. At first there was only coughing and night sweats, but the cough worsened rapidly.
程和光：前年腊月开始的，最初也只是些咳嗽、盗汗之类，之后咳得愈发严重。

Cheng Heguang: Over the past three months, she's been coughing up blood quite frequently, suffering severe chest pain, and often says she has trouble breathing.
程和光：近三个月，唾血频繁，胸痛剧烈，常说喘不上气。

Doctor Xiu: There's nothing I can do.
秀郎中：……治不了。

Cheng Heguang: The doctors in Zhu County said the same.
程和光：祝县的大夫也这么说。

Doctor Xiu: They were right. I'm afraid she won't make it through the year.
秀郎中：他们说的没错。恐怕难过今年。

Doctor Xiu: I'm assuming she's someone special to you?
秀郎中：是你什么人?

Without a word, Chéng turns his back and leaves the clinic.
程和光没有回答，转身走出了医馆。

After a while, the medicine in the pot begins to bubble over.
过了半晌，药炉冒泡了。

Doctor Xiu: Chéng Héguāng, pass me the ladle!
秀郎中：程和光，帮我把勺子飞过来!

Doctor Xiu: Chéng Héguāng!
秀郎中：程和光!

Hearing no response, Doctor Xiù steps away from the stove and heads outside.
毫无应答。秀郎中终于肯放开药炉，起身走出门。

Foot of Mountain, Riverside Village
水乡·山脚

A small patch of grass grows just outside the clinic.
医馆外原本是一块草地。

Now, that grass is a weapon. Every leaf has been turned into a blade, whirling in tight clusters on the wind.
此刻，所有被割裂的草叶都化为利器，在风中成团地狂舞。

They dart through the wind, striking one another with a sharp, metallic clang.
细针们在风中穿梭，撞出铿锵的金石声响。

Cheng Heguang: This is unfair.
程和光：这不公平。

Doctor Xiu: It is. But remember, Chéng: flowers bloom and fade, grass withers and thrives. All is governed by the Lord of Spring.
秀郎中：呵……花开花落，草枯草荣，总赖东君主。

Cheng Heguang: I'd never have expected such words from you.
程和光：……你竟会说这种话。

Doctor Xiu: Hah. I'm from a medical family. Just a handful of verses picked up in my youth, that's all.
秀郎中：哈哈，我也是医学世家出身，也读过几本话本，略识几个字。

Doctor Xiu: Not fond of that kind of talk?
秀郎中：你不喜欢这种话?

The needle-fine metal shards freeze in midair, then scatter across the ground.
所有细密如针的金属瞬时停滞在空中，而后散落一地。

Cheng Heguang: I'll clean this up.
程和光：我会打扫收拾。

Doctor Xiu: You've cleaned enough. You should head home.
秀郎中：你在我这耽搁太久了，该回家了。

Cheng Heguang: I'm not done here.
程和光：我的事还没做完。

Doctor Xiu: Yes, well, we can take care of that tomorrow.
秀郎中：明日会做完的。

夜奔
The Night Raid CH34701-06

Chéng sits on a mat, tending to his sword. The blade catches the light as it turns, casting a few bright reflections into Doctor Xiù's wine bowl.
程和光坐在席上擦拭长刀，刀刃翻转，几点流光跌入秀郎中的酒碗。

Doctor Xiu: *sigh* Always wound so tight. The real showdown is tomorrow, so why not relax a little? There'll be no coming back from this one.
秀郎中：唉，你一直这么紧绷——明天可是决战，不如放松一下？这次是真的决斗！

Cheng Heguang: I clean my weapon every night and reflect on the day's deeds. One must restrain oneself and submit to proper conduct.
程和光：我习惯每晚擦拭兵器，正好也可反省一天所为。君子应克己复礼——

Doctor Xiu: Of course. Forget I said anything.
秀郎中：行了行了，我就不该多嘴。

Cheng Heguang: It is precisely because I'm dueling you that I must prepare all the more.
程和光：……正因为是与你决斗，我更要多做些准备。

Doctor Xiu: Do you truly need the money so dearly? Is that why you're so set on defeating me?
秀郎中：你就那么缺钱，那么想赢我?

Cheng Heguang: It's not about the money. Fulfilling this task will give me a chance at a constable's posting.
程和光：……不是为了钱，是为了去搏巡检的位置。

Doctor Xiu: Ah. So you need credentials, then.
秀郎中：啊哈，投名状。

Cheng Heguang: The circumstances of my birth limit my avenues into court.
程和光：我做官的途径不多。

Doctor Xiù takes another sip of her wine.
秀郎中又抿了一口酒。

Doctor Xiu: The court again! Why does everyone have such great desires to hold office?
秀郎中：做官，做官，为何人人都想做官?

Doctor Xiu: Your father said the same thing once. He told me I was not to come looking for him again, saying, "You and I are no longer the same. I am an official now. I have a life in Zhu County."
秀郎中：程小弟之前也说，就这一次，之后不要再来找我了。他说：“我们不一样了。因为我现在是官了，我在祝县有房有家。”

Doctor Xiu: I said to him, "People must eat, must they not? Floods have brought ruin to the fields, and children are starving." But did he listen?
秀郎中：我说，人总得吃饭啊。今年发洪水，地都淹没了，孩子们都饿死了。

Doctor Xiu: I didn't ask much of him. Just to leave a door open for us, and we'd make it worth his while—
秀郎中：我也不要你作甚。你只需给我们开一扇门，我们会报答你的——

Cheng Heguang: I know the story.
程和光：我知道。

Cheng Heguang: "Case Record: Chéng Dàoguān, garrison officer of Zhu County, on account of personal ties, led bandits into the city and permitted the plundering of the county granaries; further charges include accepting bribes. All statements are entered on record."
程和光：“案照：祝县守备程道官，因私情引贼寇入城，纵掠府仓，另有受贿等情，各供在卷。”

Cheng Heguang: After the bandits entered the city, they not only looted the granaries but also vandalized and ransacked nearby homes, drawing the people into their violence. That night, 24 people were killed or injured.
程和光：盗匪们进了城，不仅洗劫了粮仓，还于周边民宅打砸，波及百姓。那晚祝县死伤二十四人。

Cheng Heguang: "In the evening, Commander Chéng instructed us to change shifts early. We were unaware of any looting. I swear that this given statement is true."
程和光：“戌时三刻，程守备命我们提前换防。至于劫掠之事，并不知晓。所供是实。”

Cheng Heguang: When the bandits ransacked the surrounding areas, there were no officers nearby to hear the people's cries for help.
程和光：所以盗匪在四周劫掠的时候，甚至没有官兵能听到百姓呼救。

Cheng Heguang: Am I wrong?
程和光：我可有说错?

Doctor Xiu: They weren't always bandits. They were once refugees, those who had lost their land and couldn't get enough to eat.
秀郎中：……他们之前不是盗匪，只是些没了地，吃不饱的流民。

Cheng Heguang: What difference does that make?!
程和光：没有区别!

Cheng Heguang: Talking on this further is pointless.
程和光：……多说无益。不必说了。

Chéng sheaths his blade and steps out of the clinic before Doctor Xiù can reply.
程和光收刀入鞘，赶在秀郎中开口之前走出了医馆。

The night grows hazy, draping a faint veil over the trees in the forest.
夜色迷蒙，为林间树木披上了暗淡的轻纱。

Cheng Heguang: ...
程和光：……

Cheng Heguang: What was I expecting?
程和光：我在期待什么……

Cheng Heguang: Some hidden, nonexistent truth?
程和光：一份不存在的隐情?

Chéng leaves the dirt road and turns into the forest. Along the path's edge, the darkening grass and shrubs bow away to either side.
程和光离开土路，转进路边的林子。末端渐黑的草木弯腰让到一旁。

Layer by layer, the dense, overlapping branches part as he moves deeper into the forest's embrace.
浓密重叠的枝叶被一层层揭开，他往更深处走去。

Cheng Heguang: There was no hidden truth, no injustice, just a transaction, one that may even have helped the refugees.
程和光：没有隐情，没有冤屈，只是一次交易……或许对流民是件好事。

Cheng Heguang: But your duty was to protect the people of Zhu County. How could you sacrifice their lives?!
程和光：但你的职责是护好祝县的百姓，怎么能牺牲他们!

Cheng Heguang: You should have thought about your actions, stopped to think what could have—
程和光：做事之前，为何不想想——

He stops in his tracks.
他停下了步子。

It's a clearing in the forest, a tiger crouching at its center.
林地中央是一处空地，空地中蹲坐着一只纯白色的老虎。

Cheng Heguang: ...!
程和光：……!

Enormous and beautiful, the tiger bears a silent blue flame upon its brow, its fur shimmering like moonlit silk.
这只老虎巨大、美丽，额上的蓝火安静地燃烧，毛发在月光下粼粼如绸缎。

Chéng recognizes a familiar wound on its forehead.
程和光认出了它额头上那道熟悉的伤口。

Cheng Heguang: That's the same tiger that attacked me a few days ago! But I saw it fall from the cliff with my own eyes.
程和光：是几日前的那只老虎！可我明明亲眼看着它掉下了悬崖——

The tiger pays no attention to him. Instead, it stretches its neck, lets out a deep, resounding call, and springs forward to the north.
老虎并未理会他。它伸长脖子，发出了一声雄浑的呼啸。接着腾跃而起，向着北方奔去。

Cheng Heguang: That's the direction of the clinic!
程和光：那是医馆的方向!

Cheng Heguang: Hold there!
程和光：站住——！

Chéng Héguāng clenches his fists, sending dozens of blades after the tiger.
几十片利刃追在老虎身后。程和光握紧拳头，利刃瞬间便向老虎收拢。

They converge on it in an instant, only to ricochet outward, bursting apart like fireworks.
——而后纷纷如烟花一般弹回四周。

Cheng Heguang: What on ...?!
程和光：怎么会！

He tries once more, but the blades are again knocked away. It seems the tiger's fur is tougher than any steel.
他又试了一次。可利刃仍被更为坚硬的毛发弹开，无法伤及老虎分毫。

It isn't long before the tiger arrives at the clinic, Chéng in close pursuit. He can only watch as it brings down the south wall with a single strike.
追逐中，老虎已跑至医馆门前，一头撞倒了房子的南墙。

Cheng Heguang: Doctor Xiù, watch out!
程和光：秀郎中，小心！

The tiger lifts its front paws high, then freezes.
老虎举高前掌，却再无进一步的动作。

Hair-thin silver threads lace around it, binding it like a fly in a web.
极细的银线如蛛网般缠住了它。

Inside the half-collapsed house, Doctor Xiù grips her bone shuttle, placing herself in front of the collapsed hunter clinging to a small wooden container.
半塌的房屋内，秀郎中紧握着骨梭子，挡在抱着木食盒的猎户前。

Cheng Heguang: What are you doing here?!
程和光：你怎么在这儿！

Hunter: I-I came to deliver this chicken soup. We cooked a big pot of it at home earlier tonight!
猎户：我是，我是来送鸡汤的……我们家今晚刚炖了鸡汤啊！

Hunter: This wasn't me! I didn't lead the tiger here! I had thought it dead already!
猎户：不是我，不是我引来的老虎！老虎不是死了吗！

Doctor Xiu: Chéng Héguāng! Get him out of here! This beast is too strong!
秀郎中：程和光！快带他走，这鬼东西的力气太大！

Her words and body shake with the effort of holding the tiger in place.
她的手臂已经微微颤抖。

Chéng leaps in behind her and swiftly lifts the hunter to his feet.
程和光跳到她身后，迅速拉起已经瘫软的猎户。

Cheng Heguang: Get up! Run!
程和光：快跑！

Tiger: ...
老虎：……

Tiger: Graaargh!
老虎：嗷呜——

Doctor Xiu: ...!
秀郎中：……！

The tiger tenses, and a second later, the silver threads snap.
银线崩断了。

Hunter: AAAHHH!
猎户：啊啊啊啊啊啊啊啊啊啊啊啊！

Amid a burst of dust and debris, Chéng grabs the hunter and rolls aside.
一阵烟尘中，程和光抱着猎户滚到一边。

When the dust clears, the clinic lies in ruins, and Doctor Xiù is nowhere to be seen. The tiger stalks toward Chéng, a severed right arm clenched in its jaws.
医馆已完全坍塌，不见秀郎中的身影。老虎悠悠然地走出，嘴里还叼着一截右臂。

Tiger: *roar*
老虎：吼——

Chéng catches a glimpse of Doctor Xiù's bone shuttle glinting between the tiger's fangs before it disappears down its throat.
程和光看见骨梭子在老虎的齿间闪过，随后便被一起咽下。

Cheng Heguang: Get out of here! Now! Go back and find the village headman!
程和光：你立刻离开！回去把乡里的保长叫来。

Hunter: What about you?
猎户：那你呢……？

Cheng Heguang: I will deal with it.
程和光：……我有办法。

Cheng Heguang: But first, I must get in closer. Much closer.
程和光：但需要离近些。

The hunter flees at full speed as the tiger lunges toward Chéng.
猎户飞奔而去，老虎已经向程和光袭来。

He slips past the tiger's attack, leaps upward, and strikes down from above.
他躲开老虎的攻击，跃起下劈。

Golden sparks scatter as white fur and cold steel collide. The strike has forced open a hairline cut in the tiger's hardened hide, but the blade is now lodged in it.
刀刃碰撞间闪出一路金黄色的火花，终于在坚硬的皮肤上割开了一条细缝，卡住了一半的刀身。

Chéng grips the blade's hilt, closes his eyes, and draws in a deep breath.
程和光紧握住竖立的刀柄，闭眼深吸了一口气。

Cheng Heguang: Sense the flow of Qi. Find the shuttle in the tiger's stomach. I can do this.
程和光：感受气。找到那梭子，那梭子一定在老虎胃里。穿过这层皮肤……练习许久，我能做到。

It takes a moment, but soon enough, he begins to feel the flow of Qi in the tiger's body.
寒冷的气渗入他的身体。

Cheng Heguang: Through the muscles, I can feel it, the shuttle's unmistakable Qi.
程和光：穿过包裹的肌肉，我很熟悉梭子的气……

The innards of this arcane creature have churned and tangled its Qi into a chaotic mass, one that Chéng fears he lacks the ability to unravel.
神秘学生物体内的气浑浊地纠缠在一起，他本无梳理这种气的能力。

As he probes further, the Qi grows cold and dense, as if it were closing in around him.
探得更深，他被冰冷、浓厚的气包裹。

Cheng Heguang: It's cold, like winter.
程和光：好冷……冬天……

???: You fool of a boy! You are not to use your arcane skill again, do you hear me? Are you trying to get us all killed?
???：听话，别再用了……想把我们都害死?

???: It's best you don't come to training tomorrow.
???：明天不用来武学了……你问为什么？嗯……

???: You're not selling the house anymore? Oh, I see. My condolences.
???：怎么又不卖房了？哦哦……节哀。

???: He's really dead?
???：……真打死了?

???: An accident. Who'd have thought a military officer would be so fragile!
???：意外。谁能想到这么不经打——一个武官！

Cheng Heguang: No! No, no, no!
程和光：不要！不要不要不要！

Snow drifts down onto the narrow courtyard. In Huanzhou, it seems the snow never truly ends.
雪从窄小的天井飘下来，涣州的雪似乎总也下不完。

Cheng Heguang: How can I find what he wants? Where do I even begin? I've already searched every corner of the courtyard.
程和光：要我找到那东西……可是哪里找得到？这院子里我都翻遍了。

Cheng Heguang: Mmm. But returning empty-handed would mean admitting defeat to Father, and I refuse to do that again.
程和光：但要是回去，就是向父亲认输了，我不想那样……

The stubborn child turns his gaze toward the open gate and beyond.
执拗的孩子把目光投向敞开的大门外。

Cheng Heguang: They told me never to go out there. That once I step through that gate, I'll never be able to come home again.
程和光：他们交代过不让我出去，说出了这门就回不了家了。

Cheng Heguang: But I have to. I have to go through it. Maybe what he wants is on the road, and if I can find a way out, then I can find a way back in.
程和光：但我得出门……我得越过这门槛。那东西在路上……门外有路。

He steels himself and takes a tentative step outside.
他下了决心，试探性地往外迈了一步。

Father: Héguāng, trust your sense of Qi.
It will show you more than your eyes alone.
父亲：和光，气的感受比眼睛更可靠。

A slight tremor ripples beneath the snow.
他似乎真的感觉到了雪下细微的颤动。

Cheng Heguang: I found it! I found it!
程和光：我找到了！我找到了！

Qi closes around the shape of something solid, and Chéng's eyes snap open.
气包裹住坚实之物的轮廓，程和光猛然睁开了眼。

The shuttle hardens in an instant, as though already clenched in his hand.
梭子霎时变得坚硬，似乎已被他握在手中。

Cheng Heguang: ...!
程和光：……！

He recalls what he learned as a child, hunting alongside the sons of wealthy families.
他回想起儿时与富家子弟一起打猎时学到的知识。

Cheng Heguang: Ahead of the stomach.
程和光：胃的前方……

A piercing scream bursts forth from the tiger's throat as its struggles grow frantic.
老虎发出一声凄厉的尖叫，挣扎愈发剧烈，想要将他甩下身子。

Cheng Heguang: Angle inward above the foreleg, beneath the ribs. And ...
程和光：前腿斜上方，肋骨之内。

Cheng Heguang: Your heart is right here!
程和光：心脏，正在此处！

Tiger: *roar*
老虎：吼——

Chéng can no longer hold on as the tiger's death throes turn wild.
程和光再也无力坚持，摔落在地。

The tiger gives one last painful roar and thrashes across the ground before stillness takes it.
老虎嘶吼翻滚几回，最终也不再动弹。

The now-metallic shuttle bursts through the tiger's chest and rolls to a stop beside Chéng.
铁梭子从老虎胸口穿出，滚落到程和光身边。

Doctor Xiu: Nicely done. *gasp*
秀郎中：身手不错啊——嘶。

Doctor Xiù staggers up to him, laboring to guide her silver thread to stitch the gushing wound on her right arm.
秀郎中蹒跚走到他面前，正艰难地用左手引导银线，缝合血流如注的右臂伤口。

Doctor Xiu: Are you able to stand?
秀郎中：起得来不?

Chéng forces a faint smile and sucks in a sharp breath of cold air.
程和光勉强笑了笑，往肺里吞了一大口冷气。

Some time later, torchlight begins to flicker along the forest's edge. The village guards have finally arrived, fully armed and ready.
不知过了多久，山林的边缘飘来火光。全副武装的保丁们姗姗来迟，手里还僵硬地举着长矛。

Hunter: I've brought help!
猎户：我叫人来了！

Headman: I thought you said there was a tiger? Where, huh? It's dead?
保长：不是说有老虎吗？老虎呢——这，死啦?

Fine snow drifts down like fuzzy willow catkins.
柳絮似的细雪飘下来。

Winter is drawing to a close.
冬天要结束了。

醉宴
The Celebration CH34701-07

The final gasp of winter snow falls, eventually giving way to clear skies.
冬季的最后一场雪下了一天，今日终于放了晴。

For this impoverished village, such a celebration is rare. Every household gathers in Master Hú's courtyard, drinking deeply and eating meat by the mouthful.
贫苦的乡村难得有次庆典娱乐，家家户户都聚到了胡朝奉的院子里，大口喝酒吃肉。

Rumor has it that this is all thanks to Doctor Xiù's mediation, marking it a feast to celebrate the slaying of the tiger and to pray for a plentiful harvest in the year to come.
据说这多亏了秀郎中从中斡旋——说是为了庆祝打虎，也给来年求个好收成。

Hunter: Make way! Our young hero is here!
猎户：让一让！咱们的小英雄来了！

Young Man: A toast to you, my friend!
青年人：我敬你一杯！

The moment Chéng steps into the courtyard, several hunters block his way with raised bowls of wine.
程和光一进院门，就被几个猎户举着酒碗堵住。

Cheng Heguang: There's no need for that. I merely did what I could.
程和光：不必，我只是尽力而为。

Hunter: There's no need to be so polite! Come, sit, have a drink with us! It'd be rude not to.
猎户：客气什么！不喝就是瞧不起我！

Cheng Heguang: I don't care for drinking.
程和光：我不喜饮酒——

Young Man: Drink! Drink! Drink!
青年人：干一杯，干一杯吧！

Hunter: Yeah! Go on!
猎户：就是，就是——

Doctor Xiù hides behind a nearby pillar, quietly chuckling to herself.
秀郎中躲在一旁的廊柱后，悄悄笑了。

Doctor Xiu: Hah. Hopefully that will get him to loosen up a bit.
秀郎中：嗯，我告诉他们用此法戏弄，效果果然不错……

Little Girl: Doctor! Doctor! My belly hurts!
小女孩：郎中！郎中！我肚子疼！

A little girl tugs at the doctor's sleeve, looking up at her with tear-filled eyes.
一个小女孩拉住她的衣角，眼泪汪汪地看着她。

She squats down, presses gentle fingers on her pulse, and slips a sugar-bound pill into her hand.
秀郎中蹲下来，把了脉，在她手里塞了颗糖丸。

Doctor Xiu: It's nothing to worry over, child. Take this sweet little pill, and you'll feel better in no time.
秀郎中：不是什么大事，你吃了这糖丸就好了。甜的，可好吃呢?

Little Girl: Thank you, Doctor!
小女孩：谢谢郎中！

Doctor Xiù lifts her eyes to see a deep-blue-clad figure sitting along the edge of the black roof tiles.
秀郎中收回目光，抬头看见黑瓦边坐着个靛青色的身影。

Doctor Xiu: That boy ... Can he really not enjoy any sort of celebration?
秀郎中：这小子……就这么不爱热闹吗?

She climbs the ladder up to the eaves, one step at a time.
她搬来墙角的梯子，逐级攀上了屋檐。

Doctor Xiu: *sigh* Even I need a ladder to get up to the roof these days.
秀郎中：唉，如今连房顶都要爬梯子上了。

Cheng Heguang: There are too many people down there. I did only my duty. There's no need for all this gratitude.
程和光：……下面人太多了，本是我该做之事，不必这样谢来谢去。

Cheng Heguang: I saw the tiger fall into a ravine. How was it able to survive?
程和光：但我仍不明白，那老虎怎会死而复生?

Doctor Xiu: Such things are rare, but not unheard of.
秀郎中：跳崖不死，倒也正常。

Doctor Xiu: Perhaps it was not a tiger at all, but instead a beast possessed, controlled by some arcane means, or perhaps it was some manner of mindless spirit.
秀郎中：那老虎说不定是被什么神秘学力量控制了……或是被寄生了，或是成了某种无智的精怪。

Doctor Xiu: I heard once that, a long time ago, a horse once jumped off a cliff only to find a great fortune, even ascending to immortality!
秀郎中：我还听说很久之前有匹马跳到悬崖下，结果反而碰上大机缘——越过精怪，直接成仙了!

Cheng Heguang: Please!
程和光：……不要打趣我。

Doctor Xiù opens her wine jar and sits cross-legged beside him.
秀郎中打开酒壶，盘坐在他身边。

Doctor Xiu: I tell you no lies. Who can truly explain matters of the arcane?
秀郎中：我可是认真的。神秘学的事，谁说得清?

Doctor Xiu: Anyway, I'm here to inform you that the clinic hasn't had a patient for three days now. You should seize this opportunity while it lasts. Remember my words about waiting for the perfect moment to strike?
秀郎中：总之，我是来提醒你。医馆连续三天没病人了，这不常见。你最好抓紧这个机会。

Doctor Xiu: Her right sleeve hangs empty, the torn hem still unrepaired, giving her a slightly disheveled appearance.
秀郎中：她右袖里空空荡荡，破了的衣摆还没补，倒显得有点落魄。

Chéng grips his left hand tightly, lost in thought.
程和光紧握着左手，不知在思考什么。

Doctor Xiu: What's wrong? Can't make up your mind?
秀郎中：怎么？下不了决心?

Doctor Xiu: Credentials, hmm, I must ask, why do you wish so dearly to become an official?
秀郎中：投名状，哼……做官到底有什么好处，还不是为了更多的钱?

Cheng Heguang: To overshadow my father's name with my own.
程和光：不是。我要用我的名字盖过父亲的名字。

Cheng Heguang: One morning, he left and never returned.
程和光：某天清晨，他走出了家门，然后再没有回来。

Cheng Heguang: Since then, our family has faced nothing but trouble. At one time, the residents even surrounded us.
程和光：那之后，我们家就有了无尽的麻烦——甚至还被县民围过。

Doctor Xiu: Why not simply move away?
秀郎中：……为什么不搬走?

Cheng Heguang: After the incident, many of my family couldn't stand the gossip and returned to their lives in the countryside.
程和光：事发之后，很多族人都受不了流言蜚语，搬回了乡下。

Cheng Heguang: "But we cannot give in to those people, and we can't run from this stain on our name."
程和光：“可我们决不能向那些人认输……也决不能逃避这污名。”

Cheng Heguang: "Don't bother with the rumors. Don't bother with those who try to kick you when you're down."
程和光：“不必理会那些闲言碎语，也不必在意那些落井下石的人。”

Cheng Heguang: One day, I will prove our family's innocence.
程和光：我们终有一天会证明自己是清白的。

The sound of the villagers' laughter floats on the breeze.
风中传来乡民们的笑声。

Doctor Xiu: Hah, but you were innocent all along.
秀郎中：哈哈，可你们本就是清白的。

Doctor Xiu: In truth, it was my fault.
秀郎中：……这都是我的错。

Doctor Xiu: She takes a swig of wine, her voice growing hoarse.
秀郎中：她闷了一口酒，声音沙哑起来。

Doctor Xiu: Many died that year, but the granary was still heavily guarded. Without an inside man, it would have been almost impossible to succeed.
秀郎中：那年死了太多人……但粮仓防守严密，没有内应很难成功。

Doctor Xiu: I asked your father for help. I told him we only had a handful of people, that we needed to strike during the guard change, grab some grain and maybe a few wen, then go.
秀郎中：是我去求程小弟。我说，我们只有几个人，只需要趁着换防，搬几袋粮食，拿几张银票。

Doctor Xiu: He took a leave of absence to distance himself, pinning all the blame on me and using the bandit attacks as a cover. It didn't cause much of a stir. No one spent much time on it.
秀郎中：他请个假，撇清关系。事后把罪责全推到我身上，拿盗匪肆虐把事情盖过去。影响不大，不会有人追着查。

Doctor Xiu: At most, he took the blame for negligence. It was simply a good deed, done without a second thought.
秀郎中：他最多背个失察的过错。这是件顺手做了的好事……

Cheng Heguang: But more than just a handful of refugees came that night.
程和光：但那晚涌入的流民远不止几个人。

Doctor Xiu: When word spread, everyone argued to come along and grab a bag of rice for themselves.
秀郎中：我不知道……我只是想救更多人。大家听说了这件事，都吵着要跟过来，给自家拿袋米。

Doctor Xiu: I figured I needed the help. After all, how much could I carry on my own? It was truly only ever meant to be a few more pairs of hands.
秀郎中：我想，我自己能搬多少？不过是多带几个人。

Doctor Xiu: I only wanted to help as many people as I could.
秀郎中：我只是想救更多人……

The people below link arms, their voices rising in clamor.
屋下的人们勾肩搭背，闹成一团。

The little girl, who only moments ago had taken medicine for her stomach, chases her friends in the courtyard.
那刚吃了肚痛药的小女孩，已经与伙伴们在庭院里追逐打闹。

Doctor Xiu: We entered the city and found ourselves at a merchant's house. Some were so taken with the black tiles and white walls that they refused to move on. I was eager to get the grain and leave, so I took a few of my most trusted men directly to the granary.
秀郎中：一进城是家商人的院子，有人看那青瓦白墙那么漂亮，就不肯走了。我着急搬粮，带着几个心腹先去了粮仓。

Doctor Xiu: By the time I returned, the situation had already spiraled out of control.
秀郎中：……等我回来，事态已经无法控制。

Doctor Xiu: Fires, yelling, and screaming. I watched my friends break into houses and come out with hands full of jewelry.
秀郎中：到处都是火，到处都有人在哭，我看见他们砸进了街边的房子，又抱着珠宝出来。

Doctor Xiu: I shouted, "Are you out of your minds?!"
秀郎中：我说：“你们疯啦！”

Doctor Xiu: Are you out of your minds?!
秀郎中：你们疯啦！

She laughs loudly, spraying a mouthful of wine.
她哈哈大笑，喷出了一口酒。

Doctor Xiu: They said, "We're stuck outside the city, starving and freezing, trudging along dirty roads. What right do these people have to sit in the city, feasting in their fine halls?"
秀郎中：他们说，我们在城外忍饥寒，奔道路，凭什么这些人就能在城内坐高堂，享美宴?

Cheng Heguang: Like what I saw when I first arrived here.
程和光：就和我来水乡的第一天看到的一样。

Doctor Xiu: Hah, indeed.
秀郎中：……哈哈，是啊。

Doctor Xiu: I stopped a few, urging them to hurry along. We still had to go back and hand out the grain.
秀郎中：我拦下几个人，催促他们快走……我们还要回去发粮食呐。

Doctor Xiu: But most refused to listen!
秀郎中：但根本没人听我说话，他们平时都那么听话！

Doctor Xiu: From then on, I told myself that those white houses held some sort of evil magic; otherwise, how could they lure good people to their doom?
秀郎中：从此，我就觉得这些白房子是种邪恶的神秘术，要不怎么会诱人往死路走?

Doctor Xiu: After all, they all died in the end.
秀郎中：他们最后全死了，不是吗?

A burst of noise erupts from under the eaves.
屋檐下爆发出一阵喧闹。

Young Man: See? I told you I could make fire!
青年人：瞧瞧，我都说了我能打出火来！

Little flames dance at his fingers, and a steady fire burns in the middle of the courtyard.
巨大的火焰从指尖蹿出，在庭院中央安静地燃烧。

Looking down from the roof, the flames seem as though they are scorching the houses. Or is it that they only cast a warm orange glow on their faces?
从屋顶俯视，火焰仿佛是在烤灼房屋；从屋顶俯视，火焰在每个人的脸上映出橘黄的暖光。

A proud laugh from the young man sets the children off, while the elders frown in disapproval. Doctor Xiù tosses her wine jug aside, hops to her feet, and lets out a hearty laugh of her own.
青年人骄傲地笑了，孩子们也笑了，老人们不赞成地皱皱眉。秀郎中丢掉酒壶，翻身站起，高声大笑起来。

At the sound of her voice, the people turn their gaze upwards.
人们听见嘹亮的笑声，纷纷抬头看向他们。

Doctor Xiu: Burn it! Burn it all! Burn down the house! Burn down the walls!
秀郎中：烧吧！烧吧！把房子都烧了，把城墙都烧了！

Doctor Xiu: The houses were burned to blackened ruins, but rice grew in abundance from the fertile soil!
秀郎中：房子都烧成黑色，肥沃的土壤里长出新的稻子……

Stern Guard: Doctor, what are you talking about?
严肃的家丁：郎中，您说什么胡话呢?

Hunter: Haha, the doctor's drunk! She's playing at being a general again!
猎户：哈哈，郎中喝醉了！又演起将军来了！

Young Man: Hey! Why are you putting it out?! Ugh!
青年人：哎……别灭别灭——唉！

With the flames fizzled out, the surrounding houses return to their original dreary state.
火焰啪地熄灭了，四周的房屋回归原本的昏沉面貌。

Doctor Xiù sits back down, leaning against the rooftiles and looking extremely drunk.
秀郎中重新坐下，向后躺倒在屋瓦上，似乎真是喝醉了。

Doctor Xiu: I'll go with you tomorrow.
秀郎中：明日，我跟你走。

Cheng Heguang: No.
程和光：……不。

Chéng unclenches his fist. The iron shuttle hovers three inches above his palm, its surface marked with faint bloodstains.
程和光松开拳头，那枚铁梭子悬浮在他手掌以上三寸之处，隐隐可见斑斑血迹。

Perhaps it was due to the tiger's strange Qi, but the effect of his arcane skill had not faded. Instead, it had permanently turned the bone shuttle to metal.
或许是因为那只诡异的老虎，锐意的效果并非消失，反而永久将梭子变成了一枚铁器。

Cheng Heguang: Shuttlebones is dead.
程和光：骨梭子已经死了。

Cheng Heguang: The people here need you.
程和光：这里的人们还需要你。

Doctor Xiu: ...!
秀郎中：……！

Intermediary: Commander Chéng, while this house may not match the grandeur of noble estates, it is a century-old building embodying both quiet wisdom and integrity!
中间人：程守备，这房子虽然比不上什么高门大户，可也是百年老屋，古雅清正！

Intermediary: Look at these walls. They have stood for many long years and are as sturdy and white as ever!
中间人：您看这墙——有年头了，还结实得很！老白了！

Father: Hmm. I've looked it over a few times now, and it is quite impressive.
父亲：嗯。看了几回了，确实不错。

Cheng Heguang: It's beautiful! Though, a little cramped. I'm not certain I'll have the room to swing my sword.
程和光：这很漂亮！就是有点窄……怕刀舞不开。

Mother: Ah, still devoted to your training? Your ambition never ceases to amaze me, Héguāng. I just know you'll be an excellent martial artist someday.
母亲：哈哈，还想着练武？真有志气，我们和光以后一定能做上武状元。

Cheng Heguang: It's too close to the ancestral hall. Just the thought of that place makes my knees hurt all over again.
程和光：而且离祠堂太近了，我膝盖还疼呢……

Father: That's your fault for being such a mischief-maker! Besides, there are far worse punishments than kneeling for two hours a day.
父亲：还不是你淘气！况且，每天跪一个时辰也算罚跪吗——

Mother: Come now, there's really nothing wrong with the size. Let's just try to be content with the place. What's the use of all that space, anyway?
母亲：行了，没什么不好的。人也该知足，要个大院子住着干嘛？

Father: Too true. Let's sign the deed today.
父亲：也是，今天就签了地契吧。

Intermediary: Excellent! Excellent!
中间人：好嘞！好嘞！

Intermediary: Oh my, look at those flowers flying through the air!
中间人：撒花了，撒花了！哎哟——

Father: Héguāng!
父亲：和光！

Intermediary: Oh, it's no trouble at all! The young master's magics are truly impressive, like scattering golden flowers to celebrate your new home!
中间人：没事！小公子这神秘术可好——撒金花了！

Intermediary: And I must say congratulations once more! You've made the right choice!
中间人：恭贺乔迁之喜！

Intermediary: May your home be blessed with peace, your family flourish, and wealth fill your halls!
中间人：祝您家宅平安，人兴财旺，瑞气盈门，金玉满堂！

白屋
The Cage CH34701-08

Foundation Office
基金会·办公室

A door at the far end of the hallway shuts, blocking out the muffled sounds of conversation.
走廊远处的某扇门被人合上，隔绝了模糊不清的交谈声。

As the four-hundred-year-old tale comes to an end, its listener scratches her head.
房间内的故事结束，四百年后的听众挠了挠脑袋。

Paper Heron: So, after that, you went back to Zhu County and became a constable?
鹭鸶剪：之后，你便回祝县做了巡检?

Chéng shakes his head.
程和光：程和光摇了摇头。

Cheng Heguang: For some reasons, I failed to become a constable that year.
程和光：……因为一些原因，那年，我没有当上巡检。

Cheng Heguang: I gave the iron shuttle to Lì Huìfēng, and he only smiled.
程和光：我把铁梭子交给厉晦锋，他也只是笑了笑。

Paper Heron: But when I met you, it seemed you'd already been a constable for quite some time. Arresting people, shouting orders—you were actually rather skilled at it!
鹭鸶剪：可我遇着你的时候，你似乎已经做了好久巡检——抓人，吆喝人，可熟练了！

Cheng Heguang: I was lucky. Three years later, another constable position opened up. I succeeded in filling it.
程和光：是我运气好。三年后，另一处巡检司又有了空缺，我便填了进去。

Paper Heron: Hm?
鹭鸶剪：嗯……

Paper Heron: So, this story of yours has something to do with this box?
鹭鸶剪：所以这就是匣子的由来?

A finely crafted wooden box rests on the wooden table in the middle of the room. The lid has been removed and placed beside it.
一个精致的木匣子躺在房中央的木桌上。木盒的盖子已经被打开，放于一旁。

Inside is a bill of exchange, listing the Hú family in the capital, and an amount of ten thousand taels of silver.
木盒里是一张薄薄的会票，书着京师胡家，款目是白银万两。

It also reads: "Bestowed upon Doctor Xiù, presented to Chéng Héguāng."
另有写明：
付与秀郎中，赠与程和光。

Paper Heron: Interesting. The East Asia branch just told me they had an old artifact in their warehouse, one that's been lying around for centuries.
鹭鸶剪：有趣。东亚分部的人只告诉我，他们仓库里有件躺了几百年的老文物。

Paper Heron: I heard it had once belonged to the Hú family, with specific instructions to pass it on to a man named Chéng Héguāng, possessor of a rather unique arcane skill.
鹭鸶剪：据说是个大家族——胡家托付的，指明要交给一个叫程和光的人，此人还必须有名为“锐意”的神秘术。

Paper Heron: But where would we find someone to honor it? Surely they've all long forgotten about this thing by now.
鹭鸶剪：上哪儿找这么个人？在我们出梅树之前，他们都忘了有这件东西。

Cheng Heguang: I've never heard of anything like this before. So much has happened since then. I never returned to that Riverside Village.
程和光：我也从未听说有这么一件物事。之后发生了太多事……我没有再去过水乡。

Paper Heron: Ah! With all this money, were you still in Huanzhou, you'd be living a life of leisure with not a care in the world.
鹭鸶剪：哎——这么多钱，若你还在涣州，荣华富贵都不愁了。

Paper Heron: But now times have changed. The Hú family is long gone.
鹭鸶剪：可如今世事更易，胡家早就不在了……

And the once valuable bill of exchange is just another useless scrap of paper.
昂贵的会票如今只是废纸一张。

Paper Heron: But why would she gift you all this?
鹭鸶剪：她为何要给你这么多钱呢?

Cheng Heguang: ...
程和光：……

Cheng Heguang: I don't know. I suppose now I never will.
程和光：这点，我应该永远无法知道了。

Paper Heron suddenly smiles, as if recalling something. She paces back and forth twice before finally walking to the door.
鹭鸶剪不知想到了什么，忽然笑了笑。她踱了两圈，最后走到门边。

Paper Heron: This elder ... Perhaps all she wanted was for you to live an unworried life.
鹭鸶剪：长辈……或许就是希望你一生顺遂吧。

Paper Heron: Either way, I've done what was asked of me. I'll be on my way. Thank you for the story, Héguāng.
鹭鸶剪：东西既带到了，小道我也先告辞了。

The door closes, and Chéng is left standing alone in the room.
房间里只剩下程和光一人。

Cheng Heguang: ...
程和光：……

Side Room, Clinic
水乡·医馆偏房

Doctor Xiu: Are you leaving?
秀郎中：要走了?

Chéng nods as he finishes packing up his bundle.
程和光：程和光收拾好包袱，点了点头。

Cheng Heguang: Matters are settled here. I need to head back right away.
程和光：既然可以交差了，我便尽快回去了。

Doctor Xiu: Here, take this medicine. It'll help with her cough.
秀郎中：这是一瓶缓解咳疾的药，拿上再走吧。

Cheng Heguang: Thank you.
程和光：谢谢。

Doctor Xiu: I'm surprised you're letting me go.
秀郎中：你放过我，我很意外。

Doctor Xiu: I thought, at the very least, you'd resent me for what happened with your father.
秀郎中：我以为……你至少会因为程小弟的事情恨我。

Cheng Heguang: He made his decision. And he took responsibility for his actions.
程和光：那是他的选择，他有责任承担后果。

Doctor Xiu: Sometimes I think you're much more alike to us bandits than your vaunted officials.
秀郎中：……有时候我想，或许你更像我们这些贼子，而不是那些老爷。

Chéng puts the medicine in his bag and stops for a moment.
程和光把药收进囊中，停顿了一下。

Cheng Heguang: Do not misunderstand me. If you return to banditry, I will show you no mercy.
程和光：不。若你再回去做盗匪，我绝不会留情。

Cheng Heguang: It doesn't matter what anyone's intentions were. Things happened as they did, and everyone has paid the price.
程和光：……只是不论本心如何，事情已经发生，所有人也付出了代价。

Cheng Heguang: Your price is to be a doctor, and mine is to be a constable. It is for the best.
程和光：你做郎中，我做巡检，这样更好。

Doctor Xiu: You had no hand in all this. It's not your fault. You are not your father.
秀郎中：这件事与你无关，这不是你的错。你那程姓的宗族，也不过是些远亲。

Cheng Heguang: I know, but that changes little.
程和光：这点我明白。

Doctor Xiu: You probably think me a rambler by now, but ...
秀郎中：或许你嫌我啰嗦……

Doctor Xiu: Why not stay in the village, hm? Live the life of a tiger-slaying hero? Why go back and put up with all that scrutiny?
秀郎中：你为何不在水乡做个打虎英雄？为何一定要回去受那些白眼?

Cheng Heguang: The offer is tempting. Slaying that tiger was indeed exhilarating.
程和光：打虎的确很痛快……

But what do titles and glory matter to a hero that has more than himself to think of?
但那又如何？他不是独身一人。

One who has a beautiful white house in Zhu County, where his mother still lives. One who is the son of Chéng. It is that hero's duty to protect that little white house.
他在祝县有一栋漂亮的白房子，房子里住着他的亲人。他是程家的孩子，必须守好这栋白房子。

And how can he leave before the walls are repainted white?
在墙重新刷为纯白之前……他怎能离开?

Cheng Heguang: In the end, I'll always be the son of a bandit.
程和光：但我终究只会是贼子。

Doctor Xiu: Constable or bandit, they're only words.
秀郎中：官贼只是名分而已。

Cheng Heguang: They're more than just words. They're a gateway to the martial arts, to handfuls of silver, and to life-saving medicine.
程和光：不仅仅是名分。还是武学的门槛，碎银子，以及……救命的药材。

"Just as the art enjoyed by the elite and the common folk differs, so does their etiquette. Outside the home, one listens to teachers and superiors; inside the home, one follows the manners of one's mother."
乐殊贵贱，礼别尊卑。外受傅训，入奉母仪。

The people of the county hold the works of sages and scholars as unquestionable truth.
县里的人都崇敬圣贤书。

"One must hold compassion and kindness for others, even when in crisis. One must carry integrity, justice, and honesty, even when in poverty."
仁慈隐恻，造次弗离。节义廉退，颠沛匪亏。

But none of them hail the brute who saved the village from a tiger.
但书里没有打虎的侠客。

Cheng Heguang: True righteousness can only be delivered through true righteous acts.
程和光：……大义需在正道上实现。

Cheng Heguang: When I become a constable, I will be fair and do right by the people. This I swear.
程和光：你放心，我若是做了巡检，一定会做正确、公正的事。

Cheng Heguang: Were I in charge of the militia here, I never would have let that tiger wreak havoc for so long, and I wouldn't have let any people die.
程和光：如果我来节制民兵，绝不会放任那老虎肆虐那么久，更不会死了三个人。

Cheng Heguang: Nor would I have let those refugees starve. None of this would have happened.
程和光：……我也不会放任那些流民饿死，这样一切便不会发生。

Doctor Xiu: You'll need to be a great general if you're to stop it from ever happening again.
秀郎中：那你要做到将军才行了。

Cheng Heguang: Once I become a constable, I will rise through the ranks: militia captain, regional commander ... Becoming a general will be within my grasp!
程和光：做了巡检，日后便有机会做百户，做千户，自然也有机会做将军！

Doctor Xiu: If only all it took were grand words, eh? But that's not how the world works.
秀郎中：口气挺大，只怕世情不像你想的一般——

Doctor Xiu: She shakes her head.
秀郎中：秀郎中截住了话头，摇了摇头。

Doctor Xiu: But then again, if you can truly live a life of wealth and glory, I suppose that's not such a bad compromise.
秀郎中：但若能富贵一生也好。

She smiles, a hint of melancholy in the curve of her mouth.
她落寞地笑了一下。

Doctor Xiu: Officials have always had beautiful homes. Perhaps your parents hoped as much for you.
秀郎中：当官的房子都可漂亮了，你爹娘或许也盼着这个。

Doctor Xiu: But should things go awry someday, you know where to find me.
秀郎中：可若有一天出了事，记得回来找我。

Doctor Xiu: I'll help you.
秀郎中：我会帮你。

Zhu County looks just as it did before. The streets are filled with pretty houses, one on top of the other, and all topped with black tiles.
祝县城内仍与走前一样。街道摆满了漂亮的屋子，青瓦一间压着一间。

Cheng Heguang: Constable and bandit are only words.
程和光：……官贼只是名分吗?

Cheng Heguang: I've been away for so long. I wonder how things are at home.
程和光：走了这么多天，不知道家里如何……

Chéng passes beneath three Paifang, and the familiar sight of his home comes into view.
穿过三道牌坊，程和光看见了自家房屋的飞檐。

Cheng Heguang: ...!
程和光：……!

Mother: That year, I had planned to sell the house and set aside some money. Those who came to look all praised it, calling the courtyard splendid and the house magnificent.
母亲：那年我本想把房子卖了，攒些钱。愿意来看的人都恭维说，真是一间好院子，真是一间漂亮的房子。

Mother: A good house keeps its wealth hidden. You'd never know whether it was filled with gold and jewels or rolls of the finest silks.
母亲：好房不露财，不知道里面是堆满了金银珠宝，还是绫罗绸缎?

Mother: *cough* They walked in full of envy but left sighing and grumbling.
母亲：咳……他们满怀艳羡地进了门，最后却唉声叹气地出了门。

Mother: Because there was nothing to be found in our house.
母亲：因为我们的房子里一无所有……

???: Because a tomb is a house for the dead.
???：因为墓是死人的屋子。

???: And a home can be the same for the living.
???：而屋子是活人的坟。

This ancient house has played host to countless masters, and now it adds one more to its history.
这老屋曾送走过无数主人，如今也只是更添了一位。

A long white banner flutters in the wind, scattering the red Mei blossoms on the ground.
长长的白幡在风中飘动，扫乱了地面的红梅。

Another gust of wind blows into the room, sweeping away the thin, pale bill of exchange.
又一阵狂风吹入屋内，卷走了那张薄薄的会票。

Cheng Heguang: ...
程和光：……

Cheng Heguang: Seeking victory in the wrong place only invites further misfortune.
程和光：在一个错误的地方谋求胜利，最终徒增的，只有错误罢了……

The bill floats out the window, soaring higher and further like a bird in flight.
会票飘出窗外，如飞鸟一般越飞越高，越飞越远。

Until it goes beyond the range of his arcane skill, becoming a barely visible white dot in the distance.
直至超出他的神秘术可感知的范围，直至凝为远处一个几乎不可见的白点。

Paper Heron pokes her head around the door.
一位朋友去而复返，在门口探出头来。

Paper Heron: Oops. My memory's terrible, you know! There's something else I forgot to mention.
鹭鸶剪：哎呀，瞧我这记性，另有件事我忘说了。

Paper Heron: I bumped into some folk from the East Asia branch of the Vigiles Bureau. They're looking to recruit you.
鹭鸶剪：我在东亚分部遇着了夜巡局的人，他们想拉你入伙呢。

Paper Heron: You know of them, right? Their job is like that of a constable's: catching thieves, writing reports, and that sort of thing.
鹭鸶剪：夜巡局你知道么？做的事和巡检差不多，抓贼、写报告之类。

Paper Heron: Anyway, I'm just passing along their message. So, what do you think?
鹭鸶剪：我只顺手带个话，你意下如何？

Chéng looks at the empty box. A barely perceptible smile crosses his face.
程和光看着空空如也的匣子，微不可见地笑了一下。

Cheng Heguang: Let's talk about it later.
程和光：之后再说吧。

He remembers an old house. A white house.
他想起了一栋老屋，一间白房子。

A house that welcomes life into the world. A house that bids farewell to those who pass.
一间迎接人们出生的房子，一间欢送人们死去的房子。

A house that has laid to rest Father, Mother, and friends.
一间埋葬了父亲、母亲和朋友的房子。

A house with clearly defined edges, square and stern in its form.
一间轮廓分明、方正森严的房子。

A house consumed by fierce flames.
一间被烈火焚烧的房子。

Cheng Heguang: I could never find what I'm seeking in that home.
程和光：路在门外……

Cheng Heguang: So I burned it down and left.
程和光：我已经烧了。